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5 signs your teeth could be ageing faster



Cavity



Sensitivity



Enamel Wear



Gum Issues



Yellowing

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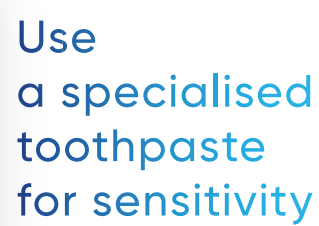
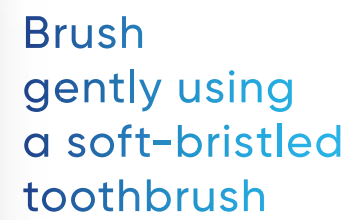
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Tamil Nadu InFocus

THE HINDU

NUGGETS OF HISTORY

A distinguished writer who specialised in *Kamba Ramayanam*

T. Gnanasundaram, who passed away recently, was a distinguished writer who had served as a professor at Pachaiyappa's College and Tamil University, Thanjavur. A scholar of both Tamil and Sanskrit, he specialised in *Kamba Ramayanam* studies. He authored *Vainava Uraivalam*, an authority on the Vaishnavite tradition.

A temple that has an outstanding structure of eight-sided vimana

The Rajagopala Swamy Temple at Mannarkoil near Ambasamudram has an outstanding structure of eight-sided vimana (*ashtanga vimana*). The 1,000-year-old temple in Tirunelveli district is said to be the place where Kulasekara Alwar, one of the 12 Vaishnavite saints, spent more than 30 years of his life.

A Tamil weekly journal founded by Pandit C. Iyothee Thass

Oru Paisa Tamizhan was a Tamil weekly journal founded by Pandit C. Iyothee Thass. It began publication in June 1907, from Royapettah in Madras, and was priced at one paisa. Issued every Wednesday as a four-page journal, it was renamed *Tamizhan* in 1908. Through it, Iyothee Thass voiced ideas of social reforms.

Paintings in natural caves were adapted into a Jain shrine

Armamalai Cave Paintings in Tirupattur are found in natural caves and were adapted into a Jain shrine in the Eighth Century. The site contains unbaked mud structures, believed to have served as resting spaces for Jain monks. The vivid wall and ceiling paintings depict themes from Jainism, including the *Astadikpalakas*.

Victoria Technical Institute was opened in Madras in 1887

The Victoria Technical Institute was established in 1887 in Madras to commemorate Queen Victoria's Golden Jubilee and promote indigenous arts and crafts. As a charitable trust, it supported artisans through exhibitions, sales, and training. Currently, it is functioning on Anna Salai. (Compiled by N. Sai Charan)

An auspicious day for the Irular community to reconnect with their roots on the seashores

For the Irulars, the Masi Magam festival is deeply tied to their culture and collective identity. They gather in their thousands on the shores of Mamallapuram to perform marriages, naming ceremonies for children, ear piercing, and tonsuring. In fact, they come in search of their patron deity Kanniammal, who they believe had left them

Bhagavathi Sampath K. I.

Masi Magam, an auspicious day in the Tamil calendar, is celebrated across the State with religious vigour. The festival also holds significance for the Irular community, for whom the occasion is deeply tied to their culture and collective identity. Members of the community often live on the margins and in some places as bonded labourers. In the days leading up to Masi Magam, members of the community from across Tamil Nadu gather in their thousands on the seashores of Mamallapuram, a historic coastal town known for its ancient rock-cut temples, stone sculptures, and monuments built during the Pallava dynasty.

The occasion offers them an opportunity to perform rites of passage, including marriages, naming ceremonies for children, ear piercing, tonsuring, and rituals in fulfilment of prayers offered to their patron deity Kanniammal. In fact, they come to the seashore in search of Kanniammal, who they believe had left them, to persuade the deity to return home with them. "There is a strong belief in the community that prayers offered to the deity will be answered and all rituals performed on Masi Magam are spiritually potent and effective," said E. Tamil Selvan, guest lecturer in the Department of Anthropology at the University of Madras, who has been studying the community.

Known for ecological knowledge

The community, designated as a Scheduled Tribe and spread across Tamil Nadu, is known for its rich traditional ecological knowledge, including expertise in handling snakes, preparing herbal remedies for snakebites, and collecting honey. Romulus Whitaker, a well-known herpetologist, worked closely with the community while studying snakes and venoms. Members of the community also engage in agricultural labour and work as wage labourers in brick kilns.

The Irulars, who participate in Masi Magam,



Full of fervour: Days before Masi Magam, Irulars camp along the beach, combining rituals with songs and dances. On the full moon day, the presence of tribal deity Kanniammal is believed to be witnessed along the shore. NAVEENRAJ GOWTHAMAN

are predominantly from the northern districts of Kancheepuram, Chennai, Chengalpattu, Tiruvannamalai, and Villupuram. For nearly a week, Irular families camp along the beach in tents, combining rituals with traditional songs, dances, and communal celebrations.

K.V. Kannappan, 43, a member of the community from Villupuram, has worked with the International Justice Mission (IJM) as the district coordinator for the rehabilitation of the rescued bonded Irula labourers. "Attending the Masi Magam festival brings a deep sense of happiness and fulfilment. Being surrounded by so many people feels like being with family, and the occasion is truly one of joy and celebration," he said.

S. Kushpu, 35, from Villupuram, said, "For the celebration of Masi Magam, we start saving on expenses days in advance and go to Mamallapuram along with our families and friends. Though we worship our deities every day, nothing can match the sense of fulfilment

when we stand at the seashore and allow the waves to engulf our feet. It feels like the deity has accepted us."

According to Edgar Thurston, who extensively studied the Irulars in his book *Castes and Tribes of Southern India*, "The Irulars periodically worship Kanniammal, their tribal deity, and Mari, the general goddess associated with epidemic diseases. On the full moon day [Pournami], the presence of the deity Kanniammal is believed to be witnessed along the seashore."

Referring to folklore, S. Rani, 54, a leader of the community from Siruseri, explained that the community gathers at the seashore to bring back the deity Kanniammal, who they believe left the community in anger during the Tamil month of Margazhi. "We create seven steps representing the seven Kannis (virgins), and at dawn, in a unique ritual, almost every family arranges flowers, betel leaves, lemons, puffed rice, neem leaves, broken coconuts, and bananas to be kept at seven Kannis made of sand. We erect a pandal,

and the naming of children, tonsuring of children, and marriages take place," she said.

During the ritual, women and men believed to be possessed by the deity run towards the sea, only to be stopped by their family members. They then turn into oracles and make predictions for the community. Families also collect seawater and take it home, believing it will bring luck and peace. "Participating in the event makes our minds light and fills us with happiness. We believe that not only our relatives, but also our ancestors, are present on the seashore," she said.

Stories about ancestors

The celebrations are also marked by vibrant songs and dances performed collectively by community members. These art forms play a vital role in preserving and sustaining their culture and traditions. Through their songs and dances, they narrate stories about their ancestors, traditional occupations and practices, and their devotion to their deity, Kanniammal.

Rani and Kannappan are also the founding members of Dolkkattai Irular Kalaikuzhu and Mullai Kalaikuzhu (artiste groups) respectively. The groups have systematically written, compiled, and recorded the community's songs. "The idea is to record our songs, and once it became more prevalent in the community, everyone began to feel proud of it," Rani said.

In addition to celebrating their heritage, their songs and dances serve as a medium for spreading awareness of important social issues such as the need for education, community empowerment, and social justice, as the community still struggles with poverty and lack of social empowerment. "In the songs and dramas, we tell the younger generation about the community's origins, tracing them as one of the ancient Tamil communities, their traditional knowledge, their suffering as bonded labourers, the social ostracisation they face, and the difficulties in obtaining community certificates and other issues," Kannappan said.

Collection of the names of animals as portrayed in Tamil classics

The ancient Tamils employed a remarkable richness of vocabulary to refer to animals. H. Chithiraputhiran, a former professor at Tamil University, Thanjavur, has compiled a specialised dictionary of animals in classical literature to recover these words

B. Kolappan

A scene of a male and female deer drinking from a pool, depicted in *Ainthinai Aimpathu*, is often cited to illustrate the ideal bond between lovers. Set in the arid *Palai* landscape, the poem describes how the *Pinaimaan* (female deer) and the *Kalaimaan* (male deer), exhausted after wandering in search of water, arrive at a small pool. However, there is only enough water to quench the thirst of one. In an act of love and self-denial, the male pretends to drink so that the female may quench her thirst, while the female feigns drinking for the sake of the male. Thus, neither truly drinks.

References to plants and flowers

This episode is among many in Tamil classical poetry that captures the intimate bond the ancient Tamils shared with nature. The literary landscape is not inhabited by animals alone; it is richly adorned with references to plants and flowers. *Kurinjipattu*, for instance, speaks of 99 flowers, and Tamils wore different flowers for different occasions. Many of these animal names have gone out of usage. To recover this vocabulary, H. Chithiraputhiran, a former professor at Tamil University, Thanjavur, has compiled a dictionary of animals in classical literature. Titled *Tamil Sevvilakkiyangalil Vilangina Sorkal: Special Dictionary-Index, Concordance, Dictionary* (Classical Tamil Literature-Special Dictionary of Animals), the

work has been published by the Central Institute of Classical Tamil. As R. Chandrasekaran, Director of the Central Institute of Classical Tamil, notes in his introduction that the elephant, tiger, bear, and lion belong to the *Kurinji* region; the deer and rabbit to *Mullai*; the buffalo and otter to *Marudham*; the shark to *Neithal*; and the red dog or dhole to *Palai*. These

associations reveal the ecological awareness embedded in classical literature. In *Nattrinai*, the hero, returning from war, sees a jungle fowl scratching the wet ground and offering an earthworm to its mate. Moved, he urges his charioteer to use the long-unused goad and drive the horses faster so that he may reach his beloved without delay. Here, the word *Kaanvaranam* is used to refer to the jungle fowl.

The Tamils employed a remarkable richness of

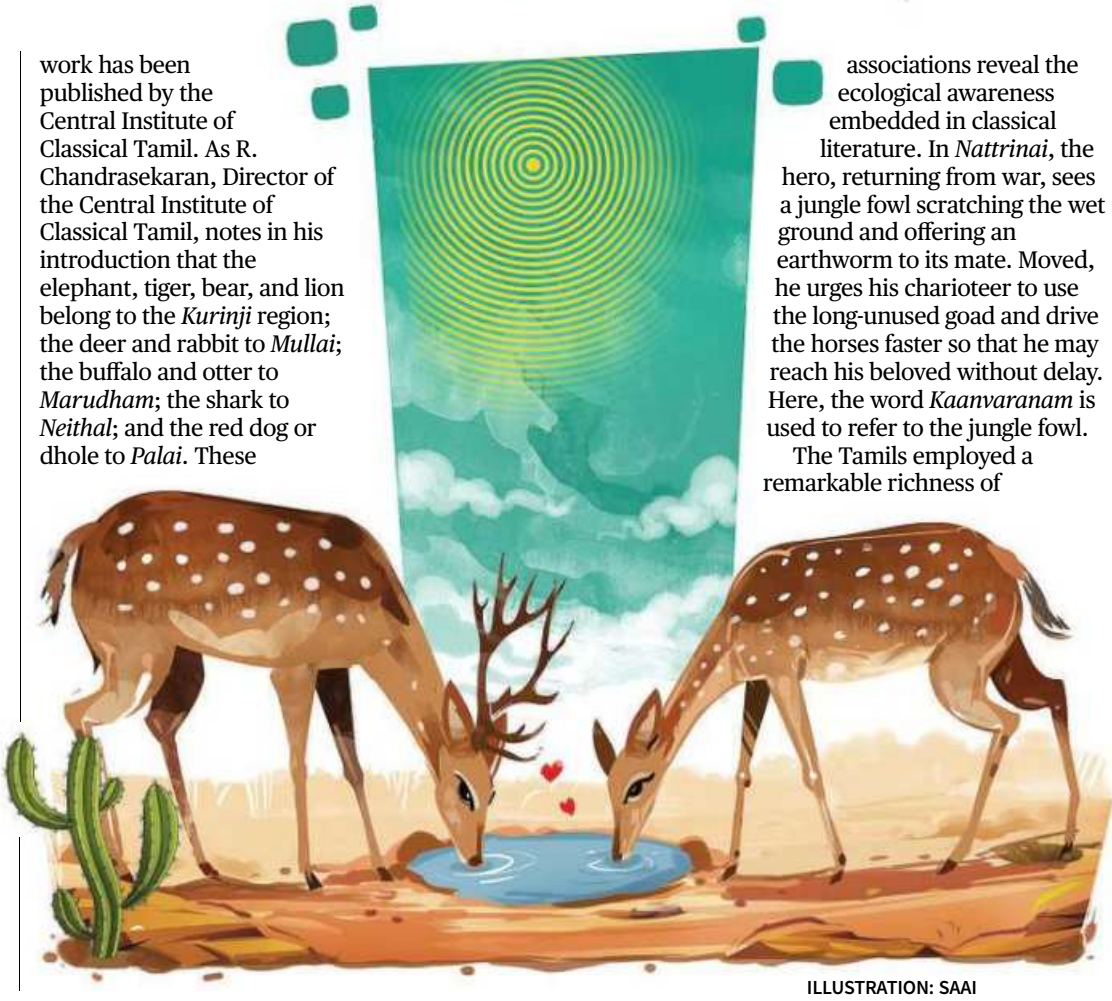


ILLUSTRATION: SAAI

vocabulary to refer to animals, using not only multiple synonyms for a single species but also distinct terms to denote the male, female, young, and even groups of animals. Deer alone are identified by 38 names; buffaloes by 20; lions by 15; goats by 28; bulls by 31; horses by 23; monkeys by 17; mongooses by 13; tigers by 20; cats by nine; elephants by 45; porcupines by five; rabbits by three; dogs by 11; pigs by 13; donkeys by four; and cows by 27.

Mr. Chithiraputhiran has listed these names in alphabetical order, along with references to the 41 literary works in which they appear and the lines that mention them. He has enriched the work by providing a comprehensive table that includes the English and scientific names of the animals. He also explains the challenges in identifying animal names, as words such as *Maa* and *Maan* are often used as prefixes and suffixes. For instance, *Maa* combined with *Ari* becomes *Arima*, meaning lion. *Maan* combined with *Ulai* becomes *Ulaimaan*, which also denotes a lion. *Karima* refers to an elephant; *Kalima* to a horse; *Kaimma* to an elephant; *Paima* to a horse; and *Mathama* to an elephant. While *Maan* denotes a deer, *Kalaimaan*, *Nalmaan*, *Paimaan*, and *Mulavuman* are also used for horses.

Distinguishing sex

Certain terms distinguish the sex of animals, while others are applied across species. *Oruthal* refers to the male of several animals, including elephant, bull, buffalo, pig, tiger, and deer. *Eru* denotes a bull, male deer, and male buffalo, including the *Kalaimaan*. *Kaduvan* is used for the male of the monkey and the cat. *Pinavu* denotes the female of several animals, including the tigress, dhole, pig, bear, monkey, and elephant. In many cases, the specific animal referred to in a poem must be inferred from its context.

Pothu is one of the Tamil words that has disappeared from everyday use. In Kerala, however, the term *Pothu* denotes buffalo and meat. According to the *Tolkappiyam*, *Pothu* was used to refer to the male of several species, including bull, buffalo, deer, crocodile, and peacock.

The unique flavour of the Dindigul cigar, a balm to Winston Churchill in times of war

During the Second World War, the British Prime Minister decided to have a regular supply of these cigars made by Spencer and Co. A permanent order was placed with the Government of Madras. Spencer and Co. shut the business in the 1950s. What is left of the Spencer Compound is a portion of the ground that has become an unkempt garden

Beulah Rose

At the height of the Second World War, Winston Churchill, sunk in his armchair and enclosed in his bunker at Whitehall, London, with a frown, would have nursed his Johnnie Walker Red, while reaching out for his Romeo y Julieta, a Cuban cigar that would give him a balanced aromatic experience. But, on that day, due to the war, the consignment from Cuba may have been delayed, and his hand would have reached out to Flor de Dindigul, from India. In a distracted manner, he would have cut the crap and toasted the edges with his trade-mark scowl slowly disappearing. As he drew the smoke in and swirled it, he could taste in the top notes the heat and roaring life of an Indian summer. Strong and bold, it would have led his thoughts to stray to his time spent in India between 1896 and 1899. And, in those few moments of quietness, Churchill would have sunk deeper in his chair, forgotten war strategies, and for a few blissful moments he would have relaxed as the heady robust note was replaced by a subtle sweet tinge bringing in the unique flavour of the Dindigul cigar.

‘Churchill Cigar Assistant’

Maybe, it was then that he decided to have a regular supply of Dindigul cigars. A permanent order was placed with the Government of Madras to ensure a regular supply of the robust Dindigul cigars even during and after the war. It was said a ‘Churchill Cigar Assistant’ post was created to keep track of the order and the PWD Division in Tiruchi was responsible for procuring and sending these cigars to London. A quarterly report was also to be sent to the government on the quantity dispatched for settlement of bills by the Governor of Madras on behalf of Winston Churchill. This quarterly report was called ‘Churchill Cigar Report’. If there was no dispatch of cigars during a quarter, a report stating nothing was dispatched also had to be sent.

Tobacco was introduced in India by the Portuguese during the reign of Akbar. Cultivation spread and before long it reached south India. Regions in and around Dindigul, especially



A shadow of its former self: In the early 1890s, Eugene Oakshott of Spencer & Co. decided to expand its cigar manufacturing operation to Dindigul. About 60 acres of land was bought a little away from the town. After the business was closed, the Spencer Compound was broken into bits and parcels, sold and resold. G. KARTHIKEYAN

Vedasandur rich in red loamy soil, were seen as ideal for tobacco cultivation. Till the early 1980s, acres and acres of farmland in this belt was under the dark-green egg-shaped leaves of the tobacco plant. The leaves grew up to 51 inches in length and had a width of about 27 inches. These leaves captured the dark mysterious savour of a ground that would bake and crack in the intense summer heat.

As the leaves turned yellowish green, they were ready for harvest. The leaves were plucked and strung on twine and left to dry. The zephyr that would float in at dusk would carry the whiff of tobacco. For a long time, the locals would chew cured tobacco that was fermented with jaggery and honey. This often gave out an earthy and sweet aroma, and many saw this as a viable marketing business. Sensing an opportunity, in the early 1890s, Eugene Oakshott of Spencer & Co. (based in Madras) decided to expand its cigar manufacturing operation to Dindigul to meet the rising demand. About 60 acres of land was bought a little away from the bustling town, which was then restricted to the Old Palani Road.

Soon, bundles of dried tobacco leaves were being brought in bullock carts to the factory in

Spencer Compound, and the air wafted with the fragrance of curing tobacco that was being pounded and rolled into cigars. From the rustic and crude moist snuff chewed by the locals, the Dindigul tobacco found a refinement and finesse in the Spencer Compound. Spencer & Co. churned out brands of cigars, such as Salisburys, Gold Mohurs, Siestas, Little Randolphs, and Torpedos.

Each puff of these cigars would have brought to the palette of a cigar aficionado the full-bodied earthy smell of a dry earth. It was the scent of well-furrowed tobacco farms at Vedasandur. Once the smoke dissipated, in its place was a seductive perfume that hinted of the first rain falling on a burning earth.

Trichinopoly suruttu abandoned

As historian S. Muthiah once wrote in his column ‘From Madras Miscellany’ for *The Hindu*, “It was Spencer’s cigars for which Sir Winston Churchill, after forsaking the Trichinopoly suruttu, had once placed a permanent order with the Government of Madras to ensure a regular supply – even during World War II. The order remained on the books till Spencer’s stopped making

Bundles of dried tobacco leaves were brought in bullock carts to the factory in Spencer Compound. Spencer & Co. churned out brands of cigars, such as Salisburys, Gold Mohurs, Siestas, Little Randolphs, and Torpedos

cigars.” By the 1950s, Spencer & Co. had wound up the business in Dindigul. Today, what remains of the Spencer Compound is a miniscule portion of the ground that has become an unkempt garden. No longer on the outskirts, this 60-acre is now the heart of Dindigul and has disappeared into an ever-growing and expanding city. Broken into bits and parcels, sold and resold, bearing numerous encroachments, the Spencer Compound lives on the name boards of shops and hotels that have been built just opposite the bus stand. The cigar business then came into the hands of business houses like Angu Vilas. But with the Tamil Nadu government’s ban on tobacco products that began in 2013, the farmland under tobacco has been sold to cotton mills.

The ‘status quo’ mindset

Going back to the ‘Churchill Cigar Assistant’ anecdote, in February 2021, while defending the farm reform laws in the Lok Sabha, Prime Minister Narendra Modi used it to criticise the ‘status quo’ mindset of the Indian bureaucracy. In bureaucratic circles, it was whispered that even after India became independent in 1947, the ‘Churchill Cigar Assistant’ post continued for decades until the State government constituted a commission for raising the salaries of government employees. At that time, the ‘Churchill Cigar Assistant’ had written to the commission seeking a raise and, well, no one in the top echelon of power was even aware that such a post had existed. The rich, complex bouquet of a well-cured Dindigul cigar has long disappeared in the urban odour of pollution. What remains are elusive notes in the annals of history and anecdotes that subtly bring the remembrance of a long-forgotten addictive-luxury to the fore.



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6	Total Days for Validity of Offer	60 days
7	Stipulated date of Commencement of work	Within 15 days from the date of issue of "Letter of Acceptance" or as per the instructions of Competent Authority.
8	Time Period	01 year from the date of commencement of work.
9	Particulars, where complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office inviting tender.	https://www.gem.gov.in Office of the Senior Divisional Mechanical Engineer, Divisional Office, Mechanical Branch, Southern Railway, Tiruchirappalli-620001.

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I, **RAMYA** (Surname) Kumar W/o Kumar Sivasailam Alagu Nelloi, born on 19.07.1989 residing at No.125/1A, Sri Varaguna Valli Flats, Thiruvalluvar Salai, Kaikankuppam, Alwarthirunagar, Chennai-600087, shall henceforth be known as **RAMYA** (Surname) PECHINATHAN THANAMMAL.

I, **P.J. Vimal Chand**, S/o. P.Jayarajan, residing at No.1.C, Pattinool Chattram, Sripurambudur, Kanchipuram District, Tamilnadu, Pincode - 602 105, shall henceforth be known as **P.J. Vimal**, for all purpose.

I, **MITHRAANUSHYA D/O KUMANAN**, residing at No.19, Moovendar 2nd Street, Pallikarana, Chennai-100, My name in Aadhar & Pan Card and Gas Bill as Mithraanushya Kumanan and my name in my school T.C. Mithra Anushya K.P. Both names are same and my correct name is Mithraanushya Kumanan for all purposes. This is application of Passport to the concern authority. It is true and best to my knowledge & belief.

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Fire and fury

Donald Trump's miscalculation in Iran is hurting the whole world

Benjamin Netanyahu and Donald Trump have brought death and destruction to Asia and economic havoc on the whole world by launching an ill-conceived, illegal war on Iran on February 28. Twenty days on, Iran continues to fire missiles and drones at Israel and neighbouring Persian Gulf countries hosting U.S. bases. Iran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz, along with retaliatory strikes on oil and gas facilities in the Gulf countries, have driven up energy prices, threatening the global economy. The irony is stark: Mr. Trump, who won the presidency twice, campaigning on opposing America's "forever wars", has now led the U.S., at Israel's behest, into another disastrous conflict. After the initial window for regime change closed, Mr. Trump sent mixed signals. He said he had authorised talks; when Iran refused, he ordered a strike on Kharg Island, the country's main energy export terminal. Israel then escalated the conflict further by assassinating Ali Larijani, Iran's Security Council Secretary and a key link between the Revolutionary Guards, who are leading the war effort, and the political establishment, as well as Iran's Intelligence Minister and the commander of the Basij paramilitary force. On Wednesday, Israel crossed another red line by attacking Iran's South Pars gas field, triggering Iranian strikes on energy sites in Qatar, the UAE and Saudi Arabia.

Many had warned even before the war began that an all-out attack on Iran could trigger a regional crisis. Mr. Trump, who until recently sought the Nobel Peace Prize, went ahead regardless. With over a dozen American soldiers killed, more than a hundred wounded, U.S. bases under attack, and rising oil, gas, and fertilizer prices, he now faces growing political backlash at home. On March 17, Joe Kent resigned as Director of the National Counterterrorism Center, claiming that the U.S. entered the war "due to pressure from Israel and its powerful American lobby". It is now clear that Mr. Trump did not anticipate such a prolonged conflict. Even if Mr. Trump wants to declare victory and end the bombing, he faces two hurdles: Iran can continue attacking targets in the Gulf and Israel; and the Strait of Hormuz remains shut. If Mr. Trump prefers further escalation, he could end up sending ground troops to Iran, an extremely risky gamble, or expanding the war to the region's energy infrastructure, a move that could cripple the global economy. The only viable option is diplomacy. Mr. Trump should engage Iran through a mediator with access to all sides and pursue a mutually workable deal. Tehran should stop holding the global economy hostage and reopen the Hormuz Strait as part of a ceasefire. A deal could still be possible if the U.S. offers credible guarantees against future American or Israeli aggression.

Losing the way

ISRO must fix issues before launch of next second-generation satellites

ISRO's NavIC constellation, for which it has launched 11 satellites since 2013, is in operational distress. Only three satellites remain capable of providing position, navigation, and timing (PNT) services, leaving the constellation unable to fulfil its purpose of replacing the U.S.'s GPS system over the Indian subcontinent. A PNT constellation requires at least four PNT-capable satellites, and India had only four until ISRO said an atomic clock onboard the IRNSS-1F satellite failed on March 13. The constellation's first-generation satellites use rubidium atomic clocks made by Swiss company SpectraTime, and which have been dogged by failure. ISRO's latest attempt to launch a second-generation satellite, NVS-02, was abortive after the machine was left in the wrong orbit. IRNSS-1F, launched in March 2016, completed its 10-year design life just three days before its clock failed. Eight other satellites have either been decommissioned, have failed to reach orbit or have bad clocks. In 2018, ISRO transitioned to using indigenous rubidium atomic clocks, developed by the ISRO-Space Applications Centre. NVS-01, launched in May 2023, was the first to carry the device; all second-generation NVS series satellites will too.

Part of NavIC's genesis was the U.S.'s refusal to share GPS data over Kargil during the 1999 war, and it continues to function largely as a defence programme managed by ISRO. However, while the space sector reforms in 2020 vouchsafed ISRO for R&D and NewSpace India for commercialisation, the absence of a national space law leaves ISRO acting as both designer and operator of NavIC, overextending the agency. Equally, India lacks a counterpart to the GPS Directorate or EUSPA, which respectively manage the GPS and Galileo constellations. The new generation of rubidium clocks also faces procurement challenges and ISRO has proposed equipping each satellite with five atomic clocks instead of the previous three. The constellation has been degrading faster than it can be replenished, due to ISRO's poor launch rate. This problem stems from several factors, including issues with the PSLV, an insufficient budget that must maintain a PNT constellation, an upcoming human spaceflight programme, several earth-observation satellites, and R&D for new rockets. ISRO is also hand-holding start-ups that have yet to get a grip on launching rockets to low-earth orbit. Meanwhile, the Union government has encouraged electronics manufacturers to support the L1 band of the NVS series for better interoperability with GPS while expecting its use by the armed forces. For all these reasons, ISRO's plan to launch three more second-generation satellites in 2026 does little to inspire confidence.

A much-awaited new GDP series with the base year as 2022-23 is now available in the public domain. On February 27, 2026, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation came out with a press note on a new series of GDP estimates and related aggregates for the financial years 2022-23, 2023-24 and 2024-25. This addresses the long-standing demand for a more accurate and realistic picture of the size of the Indian economy by updating the base year. It overcomes the limitations of earlier estimates, which relied on the outdated 2011-12 base year.

The overall size of the Indian economy in terms of GDP as per the new series at current prices (in rupees lakh crore) is estimated to be 261.18 (financial year 2022-23), 289.84 (FY 2023-24) and 318.07 (2024-25), respectively (first revised estimate). These aggregates are marginally (between 3% and 4%) lower than what were released earlier based on the previous series. The relative shares of primary, secondary and tertiary sectors in total Gross Value Added (GVA) at current prices during 2024-25 remained at 21.4%, 25.8% and 52.9%, respectively. The manufacturing sector depicts a high growth rate (more than 9%) in real GVA for both the years: 12.7% in 2023-24 and 9.3% in 2024-25. As regards the expenditure side estimates, the share of private financial consumption expenditure in GDP is around 56%, both at current and constant prices during the years 2023-24 and 2024-25.

Major refinements in the new series

Some of the most significant refinements in the methodology adopted in the new series include: first, segregation of activities of multi-activity enterprises belonging to non-financial private corporate sector by apportioning the total GVA of the enterprise across its business activities using the corresponding revenue share information of the company available in the form of MGT 7/7A data (as against entire GVA being allocated to the major activity of the enterprise in 2011-12 series); second, use of a separate blown up factor at the industry x size class level, based on paid-up capital, for scaling up the GVA of the reported active companies to account for the contribution of the active companies which did not file returns; third, a comprehensive coverage of Limited Liability Partnerships (LLPs) using Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) data; and fourth, the use of high-frequency (annual) data on GVA per worker (GVAPW) as per the Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises



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Updating the ASI sampling frame and refining the ASUSE survey methodology can further enhance the accuracy and reliability of GDP and GSDP estimates

(ASUSE) in conjunction with the estimates of the number of workers utilising the information available through Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) to estimate the GVA contribution of the Household Sector. In this context, it is worthwhile to mention that in the 2011-12 series, base year (2011-12) GVA estimates at the activity level for the Household Sector were extrapolated using suitable indicators to derive GVA for subsequent years.

The new series also introduces significant improvements in the estimation of real GVA through the expanded application of 'double deflation' and 'volume extrapolation' methods, bringing the estimates more in line with international guidelines. In addition, the benchmark estimates for 2022-23 private final consumption expenditure (PFCE) are now derived more directly by utilising data from the Household Consumption Expenditure Survey (HCES 2022-23), especially for items that are widely consumed across household groups and tend to exhibit low income elasticity.

The challenges ahead

Among the four institutional sectors, namely, general government, public corporations, private corporations and households for which GVA estimates are separately computed and then aggregated, the database of the first two sectors is quite robust. Coming to the private corporate sector, particularly the private non-financial corporate segment, for which GVA is compiled using the MCA database – a critical issue lies in allocating the national-level total GVA of companies across States to derive the corresponding Gross State Value Added (GSVA), given that the primary data are available only at the enterprise level.

In the 2011-12 series, total manufacturing GVA at the national level was allocated proportionately over States by using their shares in GVA as per the Annual Survey of Industries (ASI). In the new series, apart from ASI data (confining to manufacturing sector), the GST data is also available for this purpose. A major limitation with the ASI data is the inadequacy of the ASI frame. To illustrate, the number of companies in 2011-12, as on December 15, 2014, as per the MCA database classified under 'Manufacturing' was 135,802 (source: Changes in Methodology and Data Sources in the New Series of National Accounts, Base Year 2011-12, Central Statistics Office, 2015) as against only 67,649 factories covered under the corporate sector in ASI, 2011-12

(Table 7, Principal Characteristics by Type of Organisation in ASI 2011-2012 (Revised)). Accordingly, the proportionate shares of different States in the total GVA derived from the ASI based on a truncated frame may not reflect the reality and hence affect the State GDP figure. Remedial measures to improve the sampling frame of ASI by utilising the MCA and GST databases can be a step in the right direction. In parallel, a properly designed sample survey of active companies could be worth exploring to derive the percentage shares of different States in total GVA by the companies.

Resolving fluctuations

As regards the Household Sector, its GVA at the activity, i.e., 'compilation category' level in the new series is derived as the product of GVAPW as per the ASUSE and number of workers based on the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS). This necessitates that the corresponding estimates from the surveys are fairly reliable. However, available results from the ASUSE indicate a certain volatility in the estimates across the years for some industries and States.

For example, the all-India annual estimates of GVAPW (rural and urban combined) as per the ASUSE (covering both household sector and 'quasi-corporate' units) for the years 2021-22, 2022-23 and 2023-24 were found to be ₹163,078; ₹255,447; and ₹201,930, respectively, for the 'manufacture of rubber and plastic products' which is a distinct compilation category in GDP calculations.

Similarly, the annual estimates of GVAPW pertaining to the manufacturing industry in respect of Bihar were found to be ₹89,638; ₹117,021; and ₹100,101, respectively, for the three years. To address this problem, the methodology in the new series recommends the use of three years' moving average, wherever necessary, except for the base year. However, in resolving the issue of such fluctuations in the annual estimates of GVAPW, it may be worth exploring whether a rotating panel design in the ASUSE with a substantial overlap in the samples between any two consecutive years – similar to the procedure adopted in the PLFS – can yield better estimates.

Finally, to conclude, updating the ASI frame and refinements in the survey methodology of ASUSE can be effective in further improvement of the GDP and GSDP estimates.

The views expressed are personal

AI-powered tax governance in India and its challenges

A key tax policy challenge facing India has been the low tax-Gross Domestic Product (GDP) ratio and high levels of tax evasion. On average, during 2001-22, India's tax-GDP ratio (16.36%) was the lowest among emerging and developing economies. India loses around 4.3% of tax revenues due to tax evasion annually. At the India AI Impact Summit (February 2026), global leaders and tech titans hailed India's progress in utilising the power of Artificial Intelligence (AI) to solve real-world problems.

One problem area where the application of AI is worth examining is tax revenue mobilisation and tax governance. In this context, India's Income Tax Department (ITD)'s Project Insight (PI) initiative – aimed at leveraging AI and data analytics to strengthen tax administration and revenue mobilisation – warrants critical examination.

The benefits

Launched in 2017 and fully operational in 2019, the PI aims to encourage voluntary tax compliance, reduce high-risk cases of potential tax evasion, make tax enforcement fairer and equitable, and reduce prejudice in tax enforcement.

The PI has three components. The Income Tax Transaction Analysis Centre (INTRAC) is the analytical engine that utilises AI and advanced data analytics to process financial data from multiple sources, including banking and financial institutions, property and securities transactions, credit card and GST payments, and high-value purchases, to generate a 360-degree taxpayer financial profile.

Such information helps the ITD detect inconsistencies between taxpayers' declared income and their actual financial activities. The Compliance Management Centralized Processing Centre ensures behavioural compliance using information from the INTRAC. It nudges taxpayers who have filed incorrect tax returns to file correct returns using the Non-intrusive Usage of Data to Guide and Enable (NUDGE) strategy, which involves sending SMS or email reminders to the person pay taxes that match their actual economic activities. Taxpayers can either submit a revised tax return or stand by the initial returns



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Artificial Intelligence in India's tax administration is improving outcomes, but safeguards are needed

they filed. Deploying AI in tax administration has several benefits. First, it can assist tax agencies in accurately assessing taxpayers' risk profiles and identifying tax evasion. Second, it enables tax administrators to prioritise tax evasion cases based on the size and sophistication of evasion. Third, AI can automate routine tax administration tasks, freeing tax administrators to focus on those that require greater human judgment. Fourth, AI can enhance taxpayer services by assisting taxpayers with filing correct tax returns, answering queries through smart chatbots, and preventing tax scams.

Outcome of PI initiative, concerns and risks

The PI is beginning to show the results. After receiving nudges, many taxpayers utilised the ITD's updated-return feature to make voluntary changes to their original tax returns. Since 2020-21, over one crore revised returns have been filed, resulting in an additional ₹11,000 crore in taxes. Out of the 19,501 taxpayers contacted by the ITD as part of a targeted Foreign Income and Assets NUDGE campaign, 62% of them corrected the information originally reported in their tax returns. Also, 30,161 tax filers declared overseas assets totalling ₹29,208 crore and foreign income of ₹1,089 crore from cryptocurrencies or virtual digital assets.

The NUDGE campaign covering 6.25 lakh taxpayers resulted in corrections of false claims for income-tax deductions amounting to ₹963 crore for political donations, and the payment of additional taxes to the tune of ₹410 crore. The average time taken to process a tax refund has decreased from 93 to 17 days. Recently, using big data analysis and AI tools, the ITD discovered that restaurants across India had suppressed sales turnover of ₹70,000 crore since 2019-20 using sophisticated methods such as selective deletion of cash invoices, post-billing modifications, wiping of sales data, and manipulation of bill value.

Many advanced countries, such as Australia, Italy, the United Kingdom and the United States have successfully implemented AI-enabled platforms modelled on the PI and have generated additional revenue.

As India transitions to algorithmic tax

governance, several operational, ethical, and legal issues require serious attention.

The first is about data provenance and quality. AI systems such as the PI are only as good as the data they are trained on. They could identify outliers, but cannot always distinguish evasion from legitimate complexity. Data on variable-income professionals using prior savings, clerical errors, or joint family financial structures can trigger false positives. Without accessible human review, taxpayers must prove the legitimacy of flagged patterns.

The second is on the algorithmic bias. AI models trained on historical enforcement data can unintentionally duplicate existing socio-economic or geographic biases, identifying tax fraud more often in some taxpayer or geographic areas than others, as demonstrated by the Dutch childcare benefits scandal.

The third is on the issue of explainability and due process. For an AI-based tax compliance system to be legitimate, taxpayers need to know why they were identified, how their information is used, how the system arrives at its decisions, and have a clear, easy way to challenge decisions. There must be a human-in-the-loop evaluation for any decision with serious consequences for taxpayers.

The fourth is about the concerns over data privacy and security. Accessing sensitive financial and personal information about taxpayers creates a big attack surface for potential exploitation.

There is no ombudsman

Finally, India lacks an AI ombudsperson to review contested decisions, a requirement for algorithmic impact assessments and public reporting of false-positive and appeal-success rates, and external audits of risk-scoring models.

Without such strong AI governance guardrails outlined above, the PI might turn into a hidden surveillance system that compromises accountability and tax system fairness, making taxpayers less trusting and more resistant. India must make a clear choice: to pursue a modern tax intelligence system that is both ethical and effective.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

'Industry' definition

It is quite surprising that a nine-judge Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court of India has been constituted to reconsider the definition of industry under the repealed Industrial Disputes Act. The definition came to be settled in the Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board case (1978 2 SCC 213) and has stood the test of

time for almost 50 years, providing a democratic forum to the working class. It is perplexing that the Court is going into the correctness of the earlier definition when the new definition itself is under scrutiny. Though the earlier interpretation was wide, workers were hard-pressed to get any relief. If, at this distance of time, the interpretation is now

narrowed, many workers who had at least had a forum will be left without one. While it is true that Parliament can amend the law, any interpretation that leads to under-inclusion would be in gross violation of Articles 14 and 21.

N.G.R. Prasad,
Chennai

Children in the crossfire
The loss of children in any

war is a grave humanitarian crisis. In the context of the Iran-Israel-U.S. conflict, actions such as airstrikes, attacks and regional instability have led to casualties of children on both sides. Children are often displaced, facing risks of diseases and lacking access to basic necessities. Also, conflicts disrupt education, depriving children of learning

opportunities. While war causes massive casualties across all demographics, the long-term, structural and physical devastation disproportionately impacts children, often leading to life-long trauma or premature death (Opinion page – Data Point, "Children have borne the brunt of Israel-U.S. aggression", March 19). Global leaders, therefore, must prioritise

diplomacy over escalation, uphold international law, and ensure that all states renew their commitment to global stability and the mechanisms designed to protect children in armed conflicts.

R. Sivakumar,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the full postal address.

How far should governments go in using AI?



Isha Suri
Research Lead at the Centre for Internet and Society



Raman Jit Singh Chima
Asia Pacific Policy Director and Senior International Counsel at Access Now, a nonprofit committed to defending digital rights

PARLEY

As governments begin deploying Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools in public administration, national security and policymaking, questions about its safe usage and accountability have taken centre-stage. The issue came into focus in the U.S. after reports revealed a dispute between the Pentagon and AI company Anthropic, which refused to remove safeguards that were in place to prevent mass surveillance and the usage of autonomous weapons. The incident underscored a deeper tension between governments seeking to deploy AI systems and the companies that control them. As states collaborate more closely with AI companies, who ultimately governs the systems that govern us? Isha Suri and Raman Jit Singh Chima discuss the question in a conversation moderated by **Areena Arora**. Edited excerpts:

What kinds of state capacity could AI actually strengthen? And where should governments be cautious about relying on it?

Raman Jit Singh Chima: It depends on the problem a government is trying to solve and who it is dealing with. AI can sometimes have transformative effects, such as improving access to data or enabling better analysis, but it is often deployed without clarity on the problem, the data available, or the costs involved. There are also high-risk areas such as facial recognition, surveillance, and certain health applications, where misuse can lead to significant harm. In such cases, a ‘do no harm’ principle should apply, and in some contexts, outright prohibition may be justified.

Isha Suri: AI systems tend to work best in well-scoped use cases. For example, during the COVID-19 pandemic, image-processing tools could distinguish between different types of lung infections because the problem was clearly defined and the parameters were known. Governments should begin by defining the objective of deploying AI. That clarity is often missing. Before adopting any system, they should ask whether AI is necessary, whether less intrusive alternatives exist, and what the risks are. A necessity and proportionality test is critical. AI should not be adopted simply because it exists.

If sharing more data with AI systems make government services faster and more efficient, why should people worry about privacy? What harms are on the table?

IS: We need to question what ‘efficiency’ means



Dangerous mix: Logos of the U.S. Department of War and Anthropic. REUTERS

and for whom. Evidence on productivity gains is still weak. In many cases, efficiency claims translate into labour substitution. There is also a lack of transparency. Data collected for one purpose can be used elsewhere. Welfare data can be used for policing or denying benefits.

The idea that citizens are okay with sharing data assumes informed consent, which is often not the case. Many people do not fully understand how their data is used. In countries like India, what is often framed as cultural comfort with lower privacy is actually a function of low digital literacy.

So, individuals may make decisions without full information, while the long-term consequences unfold. That is why the state must anticipate harms and build safeguards at the design stage, not after deployment.

RC: The idea that better AI requires more personal data is flawed. It benefits certain commercial actors but it’s not technically necessary. More data is not always better. It can be inefficient, risky, and beneficial mainly to companies that rely on large-scale data extraction and compute-heavy infrastructure. There are alternatives. Smaller models, for instance, use limited data and can produce clearer outputs. There are also on-device AI systems that do not require constant data transfer to large data centres. We should challenge the assumption that handing over data is the price of better services.

AI companies say they need access to large public datasets to build better systems. Should governments treat these datasets as strategic national assets, or can they be shared with private companies to accelerate development?

RC: We should be very wary of the idea that data



If domestic systems are built on infrastructure or partnerships controlled by large global companies, then we are not truly building indigenous capability. We are simply layering on top of existing dependencies

ISHA SURI

is something that can be monetised. Opening data up to private actors creates risks for privacy, security and sovereignty. It also repeats past mistakes where public systems were handed over without adequate safeguards.

IS: Framing data as a national or economic asset is problematic because it shifts attention away from its nature as a fundamental right tied to privacy. There are also issues of consent. Citizens may provide data for one purpose, but not for its use in commercial partnerships. We also need to question who is driving the demand for access to large datasets. Often, it is private companies with clear economic incentives.

Ultimately, what we risk is a situation where public data and public money enable private extraction of value, with limited accountability. That makes it critical for governments to step back and evaluate who benefits from such arrangements and whether they align with public interest.

Governments have always worked with the private sector. Should we treat or fear AI differently in that partnership?

RC: We should learn from past digital infrastructure projects. Systems should not be deployed first and regulated later. There is also a risk that technology becomes an end in itself. Governments may expand systems not because they improve outcomes, but to justify prior investments. Large partnerships can also lock governments into costly and inflexible arrangements.

IS: Projects like Aadhaar and DigiYatra should be seen as cautionary examples. Trade-offs in welfare delivery cannot be treated lightly. Even small exclusion rates can have severe consequences. There are also accountability gaps when public infrastructure is run through hybrid or private entities.

If other governments begin adopting AI and it becomes inevitable globally, should India adopt it as well?

RC: Governments should not follow global trends blindly. AI should be used only where it

advances public interest and democratic values. Policymakers should focus on practical concerns like data protection, procurement and market concentration.

IS: The idea of inevitability is overstated and often driven by industry narratives. Governments should define their own objectives instead of reacting to the fear of missing out.

If other governments adopt AI more fluently, does India risk falling behind?

RC: If we are concerned about artificial general intelligence, the focus should be on building foundational scientific capacity.

The current industry narrative suggests that supporting large AI companies and their infrastructure is the way to get there. That may actually be a distraction from building real capabilities. If you look at India’s past, investments in core science enabled major programmes in space and nuclear development. A similar approach is needed here if we want sovereign technological capability.

IS: We also need to question what it means to “fall behind.” AI is not just an application, it is a full stack, including compute, data and models. If domestic systems are built on infrastructure or partnerships controlled by large global companies, then we are not truly building indigenous capability. We are simply layering on top of existing dependencies. This creates risks of lock-in and long-term dependence on foreign technology monopolies. It also raises concerns about sovereignty and control. At the same time, a lot of the hype around artificial general intelligence and superintelligence may be diverting attention from present-day harms, including labour impacts, environmental costs and concentration of power.

So where does that leave us?

RC: Be cautious about how and where AI is deployed in government. Focus on clear use cases, avoid unnecessary dependence on large private players, and prioritise public interest, security and long-term sustainability.

IS: Governments need to clearly define their objectives before adopting any technology. Ask whether AI is necessary, and whether the risks are proportional to the benefits.



To listen to the full interview
Scan the code or go to the link
www.thehindu.com

NOTEBOOK

Interviews do not have to be confrontational to be news-worthy

Why timely interviews are necessary and how it can help readers stay ahead of political developments

Vijaita Singh

Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk was released from detention on March 14 after being imprisoned in Jodhpur, Rajasthan for 170 days. The news, which was announced through a press release by the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), surprised many. However, readers of *The Hindu* may have seen it coming.

A week before the release, Mr. Wangchuk’s wife and co-founder of the Himalayan Institute of Alternative Learning, Gitanjali J. Angmo, was approached by this newspaper for an interview.

As someone who has been covering the Ladakh issue since 2020, when civil society groups in the newly created Union Territory (UT) started campaigning for constitutional safeguards, there has always been a deep curiosity and shock about the events that unfolded in Leh city on September 24, 2025. The protest to demand Statehood and inclusion under the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution – which would give the region tribal status, and provide more autonomy to the locals in deciding who they can sell their land to – turned violent, leaving four people dead.

Such violence from a place known for its peaceful agitation and silent marches was disturbing. It was therefore important to keep the readers informed by regularly following-up on such events. Two days after the incident, on September 26, a police team blocked the roads leading to Mr. Wangchuk’s home at his village in Uleytokpo, 70 km from Leh, and later, in his own words, “bundled” and took him to Jodhpur prison, around 1,400 km away.

Ms. Angmo, who was at work as informed by a police official that he was being taken to Rajasthan. For one-week there was no further information from the police, following which, Ms. Angmo filed a *habeas corpus* petition in the Supreme Court. In the meantime, the Ladakh administration stated that Mr. Wangchuk had been booked under the National Security Act (NSA), a provision where an individual can be put behind bars for a year without trial

based on executive orders.

For the past five months, Ms. Angmo has been living out of a suitcase, dividing time between Delhi and Jodhpur, attending court hearings and apprising Mr. Wangchuk of the judicial progress. When she agreed for the interview, the idea was to bring forth her struggle and inform readers about her journey navigating the legal labyrinth in Delhi and the emotional toll it takes to face the system.

On being asked a specific question of whether Mr. Wangchuk will continue to protest if the top court ordered his release, Ms. Angmo said he would rather seek a resolution to their demands through dialogue than pursue the path of agitation. After the story was published, there was consternation among his followers on social media that he was abandoning the movement. On March 12, a post on his X account said that he has not stepped away from activism but it will require “clarity, unity, and sincere dialogue.” On March 17, in his first remarks after the release, he reiterated that he does not see protests as the way forward and would instead prioritise dialogue. “Talks are a give and take process, both sides have to be flexible and considerate,” he said, adding that unnecessary prolonging of dialogue would hamper meaningful conversation.

The Supreme Court had finalised the hearing and was expected to deliver the verdict soon. Though he was released ahead of the hearing on the petition challenging the NSA order, and two days before the protest called by civil society groups in Leh and Kargil, he insisted that there were no conditions imposed by the Centre upon his release. The Ladakhis on the other hand went ahead with the protest on March 16 to press for their demands.

The readers and his followers may derive their own conclusions about Mr. Wangchuk’s politics and his plans ahead, but the episode showed the importance of timely interviews. Interviews do not have to be confrontational to be news-worthy.

vijaita.singh@thehindu.co.in

PICTURE OF THE WEEK

Long way down



Steady jaunt: An adult male Nilgiri Tahr descends a steep rocky terrain in the Anamalai Tiger Reserve along the Ghat section of the Pollachi-Valparai Road in Coimbatore, Tamil Nadu on March 14. With grasses and shrubs withering with the onset of summer, Nilgiri Tahrs navigate these vast stretches in search of green fodder. PERIASAMY M.

FROM THE ARCHIVES

FIFTY YEARS AGO MARCH 20, 1976

MPs question need to impound additional DA

New Delhi, March 19: The proposed reduction in income tax rates was widely welcomed but the need for continuing the impounding of additional incomes to workers was questioned by members in the Lok Sabha as the House continued general debate on the budget to-day.

The record rise in Plan outlay was described as a significant feature of the budget with the right emphasis on agriculture.

The Hindu

Mrs. C. M. Stephen, Deputy Leader of the Congress Parliamentary Party, welcomed the reduction in income tax rates, the concession in respect of house construction and the proposal to give investment allowance for stepping up industrial production.

But he did not see any justification for continuing the impounding of additional income of workers.

Mrs. Mukul Banerjee (Cong.) also suggested that the compulsory deposit scheme should be abolished as promised by the Government last year.

Dr. N. N. Kailas (Cong.) suggested that the income tax exemption level be raised to Rs. 12,000 in view of the substantial decline in the value of the rupee.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO MARCH 20, 1926

Northern India chamber of commerce

Lahore, March 19: On the occasion of the third annual general meeting of the Northern India Chamber of Commerce which was held to-day, the members of the Chamber gave a luncheon party to a number of prominent citizens of Lahore, mostly businessmen, at the Masonic Hall, at which the Governor of the Punjab who was the principal guest, was present. After Mr. Horn, Vice-Chairman, read the report of the Committee on the position of the Northern India Chamber and its activities up-to-date, His Excellency, Sir Malcolm Hailey, delivered a short address to the Chambers.

From Page One

Israel won't hit Iran gas facility again: Trump

The UAE suspended operations at Abu Dhabi's Habshan gas facility after authorities said debris of intercepted missiles fell on the site. The Bab oil field in the Emirate was also targeted by Iranian projectiles.

Qatar's state-run energy firm Qatar Energy said on Wednesday that its Ras Laffan Industrial City, one of the most critical energy hubs in the world which handles roughly 20% of the global LNG exports, came under attack. On Thursday, it said several of the company's LNG facilities were hit by Iranian missiles, causing "extensive damage".

Meanwhile, American media quoted Israeli officials as saying that the U.S. was informed in advance about the South Pars strike. South Pars is part of an offshore gas reservoir in the Persian Gulf shared by Qatar and Iran. Iran on Wednesday evening said it targeted energy facilities in Qatar, the UAE, Saudi Arabia and Israel after several phases at South Pars came under attack.

The Iranian attacks "constitute a dangerous escalation and a violation of international law", the UAE's Foreign Ministry said in a statement. "The UAE reserves its full right to take all necessary measures to protect its sovereignty and national security, and to safeguard its national interests." The Foreign Ministry of Qatar declared "the military attaché and the security attaché at the [Iranian] embassy [in Doha], in addition to the staff of the two attaché offices 'persona non grata'," and asked them to leave the country within 24 hours.

Saudi Foreign Minister Prince Faisal bin Farhan said the kingdom reserves the right to take military actions "if deemed necessary" in response to the Iranian attacks. "What little trust there was before has completely been shattered... We're going to use every lever we have... to get these attacks to stop," he said.

Later in the day, Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi signalled that Iran was ready for restraint but threatened to escalate if its energy facilities were attacked again.

Stock markets crash as oil hits \$114 a barrel

The sudden slump towards the final trading hours was due to soaring Brent crude futures price hitting a new high of \$114 a barrel and the rupee depreciating to a new low of ₹92.89 a dollar.

All the 21 sectoral indices were down with Nifty Auto down more than 4%.

Increasing risk of inflation due to the war in West Asia led gold tumbling 3% to \$4,650 an ounce. "The decline was largely driven by the Federal Reserve's hawkish stance, with any potential easing now contingent on clear signs of moderating inflation," said Kaynat Chainwala, AVP Commodity Research, Kotak Securities.

Markets witnessed the perfect storm when Israel attacked the world's largest gas field in Iran and the latter retaliated by attacking major energy sites in the Gulf region. This sent crude prices soaring to \$114 a barrel.

On the global macro front, the U.S. central bank - the Federal Reserve - held interest rates steady ranging between 3.5% and 3.75%, signalling higher inflation could stymie further rate cuts in 2026. But a rate hike by the U.S. Fed would make American markets more attractive for foreign funds, intensifying their current exit from the Indian market.

"Going ahead, markets appear to be in a phase of heightened fragility, where sentiment is being driven by rapidly evolving geopolitical developments and a sharp rise in crude prices. Given the intensifying tensions around energy infrastructure in West Asia, we remain cautious on the market in the near term and expect volatility to persist," said Siddhartha Khemka, Head of Research, Wealth Management, Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd.

"Nifty breached its key prior swing low of 22,955, confirming bears' return with a vengeance...." said Vinay Rajani, Senior Technical Research Analyst, HDFC Securities.

'Iran may allow more Indian ships via Strait'

"Automatic Identification System data, while sparse, suggests India's LPG carrier *Shivalik* took an unusual route around Iran's Larak Island and through Iranian territorial waters so IRGC Navy and port authority could assess visual confirmation of the identity of the vessel," Mr. Meade said.

LLI has reported that nine ships have exited through Iran's supposedly safe corridor and at least one tanker was allowed to pass through for payment of \$2 million to Iran.

Reliable sources in India, meanwhile, said that with the situation in West Asia continuing to escalate, Indian ships stuck in the Strait of Hormuz for more than two weeks have been asked to "stay put" for now. The process for Indian ships and others has been paused after the Israeli strikes on Iran's largest gas fields at South Pars, they said.

Last week on March 12, after Prime Minister Narendra Modi spoke to Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian, officials said they began talks on 24 ships, then stranded west of Hormuz. Iran said they would allow two Indian ships along with those of a few other countries to pass the strait.

The vessels that were allowed to pass were asked to traverse "through a specific route close to the Iranian coast", a source confirmed.

Modi, Jaishankar call for dialogue as strikes escalate

French President says India and France are working closely together to reduce tensions in West Asia; recent attacks against energy installations are 'deeply disturbing', says MEA spokesperson

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

India and France are "working closely together" to de-escalate tensions in West Asia, French President Emmanuel Macron said, after a conversation with Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday, one of many calls that Mr. Modi and External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar made to leaders worldwide.

As Israel and Iran both stepped up attacks on energy installations and gas fields across the Gulf region, the government said this targeting of civilian infrastructure was "deeply disturbing" and "unacceptable", calling for them to stop.

In the past, New Delhi had condemned Iran's attacks on Gulf states, but not the strikes by the United States and Israel. Just last week, India had co-sponsored a UN Security Council resolution that only condemned strikes by Iran on its neighbours. In a marked shift, however, the government is now emphasising the need to avoid at-



Since February 28, Prime Minister Modi has spoken to counterparts across the Gulf states, Iran and Israel and other countries. PTI

tacking civilian infrastructure "across the region".

"Recent attacks against energy installations in different locations across this region are deeply disturbing and only serve to further destabilise an already uncertain energy scenario for the whole world," the Ministry of External Affairs' official spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said on Thursday.

Speaking to Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani, the Amir of Qatar, Mr. Modi said India stands in solidarity with Qatar, that suffered major losses from the Iranian strikes on the Ras Laffan gas facility, and

"strongly condemns the attacks on the region's energy infrastructure".

In a flurry of telephone calls, the Prime Minister also spoke to the leaders of Jordan, Malaysia and Oman. Since February 28, Mr. Modi has spoken to his counterparts across the Gulf states, Iran, and Israel, and a number of other leaders, and also with U.S. President Donald Trump.

Mr. Jaishankar met with UAE Minister of State for International Cooperation Reem Al Hashimy, and spoke to Israeli Foreign Minister Gideon Saar over the telephone. India has also

been engaging all leaders of the BRICS grouping that it is chairing this year, although it has not been able to craft a consensus statement due to differences between Iran and the UAE, which are both members.

The lack of a statement from BRICS is in contrast to the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) grouping, which includes Iran but not the UAE. The SCO issued a statement on March 2 condemning the strikes on Iran as well as the ensuing conflict.

"BRICS membership and SCO membership are two different categories. If you look at the members, you will get an answer as to why we are having issues in forming a consensus," Mr. Jaiswal said, in response to a question from *The Hindu*.

In his phone calls on Thursday, Mr. Modi said he had called for a return to "dialogue and diplomacy". Referring to the call with Mr. Macron, he said: "We look forward to continuing our close coordination to advance peace and stability in the region and beyond."

MEA receives plea for consular access for 6 Ukrainian nationals

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Three days after six Ukrainian nationals and a U.S. citizen were produced in court by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) for working with ethnic armed organisations in Myanmar by entering via Mizoram, officials here confirmed that they have received request for "consular access" for the Ukrainian nationals from the Embassy of Ukraine. Ministry of External Affairs spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said on Thursday that the six Ukrainians and an American were found to be "wanting" of the required permits for visiting Mizoram.

"Relevant agencies of the Government of India

are investigating the case... Yes. We have received consular access request and this will be addressed keeping in mind the legal requirements that are involved in this particular case," said Mr. Jaiswal. The official remarks from India came soon after the Embassy of Ukraine expressed "serious concern" over the arrest, raising questions over the reports that the arrests were "prompted by information provided by the Russian side".

"Ukraine firmly rejects any insinuations regarding the possible involvement of the Ukrainian state in supporting terrorist activities," said the Embassy of Ukraine in a statement underscoring the need for "verified facts and transparent procedures".

Unfenced border with Myanmar in focus after arrest of seven foreigners

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Amid the recent arrest of seven foreign nationals, including six Ukrainians and a U.S. citizen, who allegedly crossed illegally into Myanmar via Mizoram to train armed ethnic groups in weapons handling and drone operations, data show that 43 km of the total 1,643 km border with Myanmar has been fenced so far.

The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has accused the foreigners of importing drones from Europe to Myanmar via India for the use of ethnically armed groups (EAGs) in the country. The government recently informed a parliamentary panel that to check illegal migration, trafficking and insurgent activities along the Myan-



The fencing project will include gates that record biometrics and photographs of people who cross the border. FILE PHOTO

mar border, "coordination with local communities, Myanmar Army and associated security agencies is maintained" and a "joint counter-drone mechanism with monthly reporting and biometrics and gate passes were introduced.

However, over the past two years, the number of gates has declined to 38 and only 20 are now functional, a government

New education Bill is 'constitutional overreach': Cong.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The proposed legislation to restructure the regulatory framework of higher education represents constitutional overreach by the Union government, the Congress said on Thursday. The Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan (VBSA) Bill, 2025, was introduced without consulting States, bureaucratises higher education, and hands over grant-giving powers to the Education Ministry that is controlled by politicians, Congress communications chief Jairam Ramesh said, in a statement explaining the party's opposition to the Bill.

Mr. Ramesh added that a Parliamentary panel has flagged a high number of vacancies at existing regulatory bodies, including the University Grants Commission (UGC) and the All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE). The Bill proposes to subsume these bodies, and the National Council for Teacher Education (NCTE) into a single 12-member Commission, under which three separate Regulatory, Ac-



Jairam Ramesh

creditation, and Standards Councils will operate.

"This concerning news comes at a time when there is already a move to restructure the architecture of higher education regulation through the VBSA Bill, 2025," Mr. Ramesh said.

Though the Centre has cited Entry 66 of the Union List in the Constitution to defend its right to introduce the Bill, the legislation gives the proposed new umbrella Commission "powers beyond this scope and specifically encroach on State government powers", he added.

The Bill seeks to divide UGC's grant-giving powers from the regulatory structure to minimise conflicts of interest, with the government saying future funding mechanisms will be designed by the Education Ministry.



Vikram Doraiswami

Doraiswami named India's Ambassador to China

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

India has appointed Vikram K. Doraiswami as the next Ambassador to China, the Ministry of External Affairs announced on Thursday. Mr. Doraiswami is currently the High Commissioner of India to the United Kingdom.

"He is expected to take up the assignment shortly," the Ministry's statement said. Currently, Pradeep Kumar Rawat is serving as India's Ambassador to China.

Rajnath stresses need for self-reliant drone industry

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

Calling for self-reliance in drone technology, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Thursday urged industry stakeholders to work in mission mode to establish India as a global hub for indigenous drone manufacturing by 2030.

Addressing micro, small, and medium enterprises (MSMEs), start-ups, innovators and policymakers at the National Defence Industries Conclave held at the Manekshaw Centre, Mr. Singh noted that true self-reliance goes beyond assembling drones and must extend to manufacturing critical components domestically.

"From moulds to software, engines and batteries, everything must be produced in India," he said, highlighting that many countries still rely heavily on imports, particular-



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh visits a stall during the National Defence Industries Conclave in New Delhi. @DEFPDINDIA/X/PTI

ly from China, for key drone components.

Citing ongoing global conflicts such as the Russia-Ukraine war and tensions between Iran and Israel, the Defence Minister said these developments have established drones and counter-drone systems as decisive tools in modern warfare.

He stressed that building a robust domestic drone ecosystem was critical to ensuring strategic autonomy.

Mr. Singh also highlighted the importance of collaboration across large industries, MSMEs, start-ups and innovators. He assured full support from the government to accelerate this transformation.

During the event, Mr. Singh launched the 14th edition of the Defence India Start-up Challenge (DISC-14) and the fourth edition of ADITI challenges under the Innovations for Defence Excellence (iDEX) framework.

SC reserves verdict on ambit of 'industry'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A nine-judge Bench of the Supreme Court reserved judgment on Thursday on whether educational institutions, hospitals, and sovereign functions of the government and its instrumentalities would fall within the definition of 'industrial activity' under the Industrial Disputes Act.

The Bench, headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, reserved its verdict

on the third and final day of oral arguments.

The question of law before the proposed Bench concerns a 1978 judgment in *Bangalore Water Supply and Sewerage Board vs. A. Rajappa*.

The 1978 judgment had expanded the ambit of 'industry' to hold that any systematic activity (whether or not for profit), including charitable and government-run services, were an industry if they met the parameters of a triple test.



Master Toni, Indraprastha Apollo Hospital No.APD1.0011844940, 4 years is Diagnosed to be Suffering from Thalassemia Major. He is currently on supportive care for the same. The only Curative Treatment for Thalassemia major is Bone Marrow Transplant. The Estimated cost of the transplant is approximate Rs.29,00,000/-.

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‘Transfers are interference of highest order’

Expressing alarm over the “arbitrary removal of more than 50 senior officials”, West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Thursday said the transfers were “political interference of the highest order”.

Since the announcement of election dates, the Election Commission has transferred

several key officials, including the Chief Secretary, Home Secretary, and the Director-General of Police.

Ms. Banerjee described the move as a “systematic politicisation of institutions meant to remain impartial, and a direct assault on the Constitution”. She said officers removed from their posts were being deputed as election observers. “This is not governance. It reflects sheer incompetence being passed off as authority,” she said on social media.



Mamata Banerjee has criticised the EC over the transfer of over 50 senior officials.

Pradyut’s son withdraws as Cong. candidate

Prateek Bordoloi has withdrawn his candidature from the Margherita Assembly constituency in Assam, a day after his father and Nagaon MP, Pradyut Bordoloi, joined the Bharatiya Janata Party.

In a letter addressed to Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Thursday, the son said the

“present circumstances following my father’s decision to join another political party” were inappropriate for him to continue as a candidate.

The senior Bordoloi quit Congress on Tuesday and joined the BJP the next day. The BJP nominated him as its candidate from the Dispur Assembly seat on Thursday.

Mr. Prateek insisted that his decision was guided by his respect for the organisation and his desire to uphold the values and discipline of the Congress party.



BJP has turned the EC into its weapon to win elections through deceit. What is happening in Bengal is exactly what happened in the Delhi election

ARVIND KEJRIWAL
AAP convener

Left Front releases second list for Bengal

The Left Front released a list of 32 candidates on Thursday for the West Bengal Assembly election. This is the Front’s second list, after 192 names were released on Monday.

The Communist Party of India-Marxist (CPI-M) has fielded nominees in key constituencies across south Bengal.



UDF is bowling googlies particularly to the Left Democratic Front because they are on a sticky wicket and we can catch them on that

SHASHI THAROOR
Congress leader



Kerala BJP president Rajeev Chandrashekar with M.J. Job, who will contest from Alappuzha. ANI

BJP reshapes its Kerala playbook, bets big on Christian votes

Nistula Hebbar
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) fielding seven Christian candidates for the Kerala election reflects the party’s gambit to reach out to the Christian community, traditionally supporters of the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF), in the State.

According to 2011 Census, Christians make up around 18.4% of Kerala’s population.

In its two candidate lists so far, the BJP has named Union Minister George Kurian from Kanjirappally, P. C. George from Poonjar, Anoop Antony Joseph from Thiruvalla, Shone George from Pala, Lijoy Paul from Mankada, Bijoy Thomas from Ollur, and M. J. Job from Alappuzha.

‘Support evident’

The BJP has been raising issues concerning the Christian community as part of its strategy, including extending support to the community in the Munambam land case involving a dispute between the Waqf Board and locals. The State BJP intervened constructively when two nuns were arrested in Chhattisgarh on charges of trafficking without evidence. Interestingly, the party has steered clear of its marquee issues in northern India, the sale and consumption of beef and other dietary injunctions.

But will the candidatures and outreach programmes enable the party to overcome its Hindutva image in a State of diversity?

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Mr. Joseph, the BJP’s State general secretary and Thiruvalla candidate, considered it “ironic” that the BJP was being characterised as communal.

“It is an irony that the BJP is considered to be a party of a particular section of Kerala, when BJP is the real secular party of Kerala, holding the principle of ‘Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas’ of Prime Minister Modi. Here in Kerala, a party like the Indian Union Muslim League which has the name of a particular religion is called secular, whereas BJP which has *janata* (people) in its name is called communal. This narrative has been set by Congress and CPI(M) to polarise minority votes,” he said.

Mr. Joseph said the BJP’s efforts to gain the support of the Christian community were evident in Union Minister Suresh Gopi’s victory in the Thrissur Lok Sabha seat. “The community’s votes will be the reason for the BJP’s victory in these polls,” he said.

The BJP leader said the Congress was “rudderless” in the State and it would pay the price for neglecting the issues of the Christian community.

Mr. Joseph is considered one of the Christian faces projected by the BJP who is not a newcomer, but has been through the party organisation. He was national secretary of the Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha team and is also responsible for the Modi archive project, which is digitally collecting oral and written records related to Prime Minister Modi’s life.

New playbook

The BJP has had to be counterintuitive with regard to its strategy in Kerala, after its success in Hindi-speaking States in northern India.

A new playbook in the State has long been in the making, with execution to be tested in these Assembly polls.

Dravidian titans face a new disruptor as T.N. girds for a high-stakes contest

The principal players have made compromises to strengthen alliances; while DMK has framed it as a Tamil Nadu versus New Delhi battle, AIADMK, which is in alliance with BJP, is confronting it directly; actor Vijay has cast it as a TVK-DMK contest, even as NTK seeks to consolidate its position

IN FOCUS

D. Suresh Kumar
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu is gearing up for an intense election battle anchored by alliances led by the old Dravidian warhorses – the DMK and the AIADMK – with a new disruptor, Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), founded by film star C. Joseph Vijay, shaking up the political landscape. The spirited presence of Seeman’s Naam Tamilar Katchi (NTK), a Tamil nationalist outfit that has organically grown into an Election Commission-recognised State party in just over a decade, completes the quadrangular contest for the 234 Assembly seats.

Cognisant of the potential disruption on the cards, the principal players have left nothing to chance and responded by making the required compromises to forge stronger alliances.

Rainbow coalition

The DMK, led by Chief Minister M.K. Stalin, has gone beyond retaining its nine-year-old rainbow alliance comprising the Congress, CPI, CPI(M), MDMK, Viduthala Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK), IUML, and others – largely bound by their ideological opposition to the BJP. Its Secular Progressive Alliance now comprises over 20 parties, with the inclusion of the late Vijayakant’s DMDK, Kamal Haasan’s Makkal Needhi Maiam, and several sub-regional outfits. Not

just that, the DMK has also opened its doors to former AIADMK leaders, including three-time Chief Minister O. Panneerselvam and his supporters.

Mr. Stalin, in his quest to prevent vote spillover in the event of shrinking victory margins whenever a strong disruptor enters the arena, has not hesitated to make costly trade-offs. For instance, he conceded a Rajya Sabha berth to the ideologically agnostic DMDK to prevent it from moving into the AIADMK-BJP fold. Despite irritation within the DMK over some Congress functionaries publicly taunting the ruling party, the Congress has been allotted 28 seats, three more than in the previous election, along with a Rajya Sabha berth. These decisions have triggered fresh challenges for the DMK, with the CPI(M) and the VCK now seeking increased seat allocations.

Banking on the strength of this expanded alliance and its record on welfare schemes, such as those involving direct cash transfers and women empowerment, Mr. Stalin is pushing for what he calls a “Dravidian Model 2.0” government. He is also attempting to overturn the record of the DMK not having retained power in consecutive elections since the formation of the first AIADMK government in 1977.

EPS in charge

Seeking to dislodge the DMK, BJP strategist and Union Home Minister Amit Shah stepped in 11 months ago to bring a somewhat

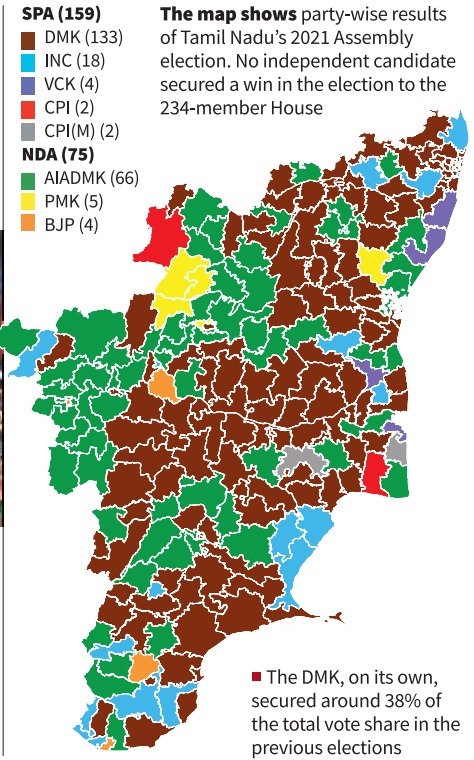
The T.N. battle

A look at the Assembly results in 2021 where the contest was largely triangular. The upcoming polls in the State are expected to be a quadrangular contest among the DMK- and AIADMK-led alliances, the NTK and the TVK



The table below shows the alliance-wise vote shares secured in 2021 Assembly election

Alliance	Vote share
Secular Progressive Alliance (SPA)	45.4%
National Democratic Alliance	39.7%
Naam Tamilar Katchi (NTK)	6.6%
Others	8.3%



reluctant AIADMK back into the NDA fold, assuring the election would be fought under the leadership of Leader of the Opposition Edappadi K. Palaniswami.

Mindful of the need for a stronger alliance to take on the DMK, Mr. Shah persuaded the AIADMK leader to accommodate former party rebel T.T.V. Dhinakaran’s Amma Makkal Munetra Kazhagam in the alliance. However, Mr. Palaniswami showed no such concessions to Mr. Panneerselvam or V.K. Sasikala, the former aide of the late Chief Minister Jayalalithaa. He also expelled senior leader K.A. Sengottaiyan, who eventually joined the TVK. Mr. Pala-

niswami also succeeded in roping in the PMK led by Anbumani following the latter’s estrangement from his father and party founder S. Ramadoss. Several smaller parties with pockets of influence and caste groups have also joined the alliance.

While the NDA has expanded, its principal constituents remain divided on one key question – the nature of the government to be formed if they win. Mr. Palaniswami has been emphatic that it would be an AIADMK government, whereas BJP leaders, including Prime Minister Narendra Modi, have pitched for a coalition “double-engine” NDA government. Nevertheless, it has gone

full throttle against the DMK, attacking it over issues of law and order, corruption, maladministration, and dynastic politics.

The third dimension

Challenging this dominantly bipolar landscape is Mr. Vijay, who has been drawing frenzied crowds, particularly among the youth and women, since launching the TVK two years ago. Positioning the DMK as his political adversary and the BJP as his ideological opponent, Mr. Vijay has revived an anti-corruption plank while aligning his policies with the welfare-driven framework associated with Dravidian politics. His party reflects the culture of hero worship, pos-

ter politics, and aggressive attacks on rivals that have long characterised Tamil Nadu’s political theatre.

Mr. Vijay had dangled the prospect of power-sharing with parties willing to align with him. Yet, no party chose to gravitate towards his formation. Still, analysts widely project he could secure a double-digit vote share. Whether that expectation translates into electoral success remains uncertain, given that the TVK lacks the deep organisational machinery that the Dravidian majors possess.

Also In the fray is the NTK, which has fielded candidates in all 234 constituencies, half of them women. Unlike Mr. Vijay, Mr. Seeman harbours no immediate ambitions of becoming Chief Minister. For him, improving on the party’s 8% vote share would itself be a measure of success. On the sidelines are V.K. Sasikala and S. Ramadoss, who may at best chip away small pockets of community-based votes that might otherwise accrue to the AIADMK alliance.

Overall, the election is being framed in sharply different ways by the principal players. Mr. Stalin has pitched it as a contest between Tamil Nadu and New Delhi, effectively casting it as DMK versus the BJP-led NDA. Mr. Palaniswami is confronting him directly in that battle. Mr. Vijay, meanwhile, has framed it as a TVK versus DMK contest, while Mr. Seeman is projecting himself as an alternative.

Congress defectors on BJP’s list of 88 names for Assam

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

Four of five recent defectors from the Congress, including one MP and three MLAs, have found their way into the Bharatiya Janata Party’s list of 88 candidates for the April 9 Assembly election in Assam.

Missing from the first list, released by the BJP’s central office in New Delhi on Thursday, are 19 MLAs, including Deputy Assembly Speaker Numal Momin (Bokajan constituency), Minister Nandita Garlosa (Haflong), and Phanidhar Talukdar, who defected after winning the 2021 polls from Bhabanipur on All India United Democratic Front ticket.

The BJP rewarded Nagaon MP Pradyut Bordoloi, who quit the Congress two days ago, with a nomination from the Dispur seat, currently held by its five-time MLA Atul Bora. The party also named former State Congress president Bhupen Kumar Borah from the Bihpura constituency.



Himanta Biswa Sarma will contest from Jalukbari.

Kamalakhya Dey Purkayastha, who won the 2021 polls from Barak Valley’s Karimganj North, is the BJP’s candidate from Katigora, while his counterpart Sashi Kanta Das has been fielded from Raha seat. The latter won this seat for the Congress in 2021.

Two more MLAs, who won the 2021 election on Congress ticket, are on the list of candidates. They are Sushanta Borgohain and Rupiyoti Kurmi.

Eyeing sixth term

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma is the BJP’s candidate from Jalukbari, one of four constituencies

in Kamrup Metropolitan district, much of which is covered by Guwahati. A notable omission in one of the other three seats – New Guwahati – is former State BJP president Siddhartha Bhattacharya, who played a key role in bringing Mr. Sarma to the BJP from the Congress in 2015.

Many in the BJP said this was expected as the current party leadership has been phasing out the “old brigade”.

Mr. Bora, among the older set of leaders, said the list was shocking when “everyone knew I will get a ticket”.

Hours after the BJP declared its list of candidates, Dholai MLA Nihar Kanti Das resigned from the primary membership of the party, claiming lack of recognition of his work.

Chief Minister Sarma said it was natural for those left out to be angry.

Of the 88 candidates, six are women. Barring Minister Ajanta Neog (Golaghat seat), the women candidates are new faces.

Rupa Ganguly, 2 former MPs on BJP’s second list in Bengal

Shiv Sahay Singh
Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Thursday announced candidates for 112 seats, which included three former MPs. The party, however, maintained silence on the candidature of Abhaya’s mother.

On Thursday, the mother of the doctor who was raped and murdered at the R.G. Kar Hospital in Kolkata in August 2024 told presspersons that she had informed the BJP leadership about her decision to contest the Assembly polls from Panihati seat in North 24 Parganas district. The BJP has not yet announced a candidate for the seat.

The party had earlier announced candidates for 144 seats. It has made one change to that list, replacing the candidate for the Bishnupur seat.

The party has named three former MPs – former Rajya Sabha member Rupa Ganguly from Sonarpur South in South 24 Parga-



Rupa Ganguly will contest from Sonarpur South.

nas, Arjun Singh from Noapara in North 24 Parganas, and Nisith Pramanik from Mathabhanga in Cooch Behar district.

It has fielded advocate Koustav Bagchi from Barrackpore seat and another lawyer, Tarunjyoti Tiwari, is the candidate in Rajarhat Gopalpur.

The party seems to have placed its faith in the old guard by fielding Ritesh Tewari from Belgachia Kashi in Kolkata. In central Kolkata, the BJP has fielded heavyweight candidates like the party’s West Bengal vice-president Tapas Roy, from the Maniktala Ganguly from Sonarpur South in South 24 Parga-

Rekha Patra, a woman leader who emerged from the Sandeshkhali movement, has been fielded in Hingalganj in North 24 Parganas. The BJP candidate for Behala Paschim is Indranil Khan, who is the State president of the BJP Yuva Morcha. BJP leader Suwendu Adhikari’s brother Dibyendu Adhikari has been fielded from Egra in Purba Medinipur district.

The BJP has also given ticket to actor-turned-politician Hiran Chatterjee from Shyampur in Howrah. Mr. Chatterjee, a sitting MLA, had to vacate the Kharagpur Sadar seat for BJP heavyweight Dilip Ghosh.

The BJP has also given ticket to three MLAs from the Matua-dominated region. Ashok Kirtania will contest from Bongaon Uttar, Swapan Majumdar from Bongaon South, and Subrata Thakur from Gaighata. Former Bongaon district BJP president and Bongaon municipality councillor Devdas Mandal will contest from Habra.

INBRIEF



CBI questions Anil Ambani in ₹2,929-crore cheating case

The Central Bureau of Investigation on Thursday questioned industrialist Anil Ambani for nearly eight hours in connection with a ₹2,929-crore cheating case, registered against Reliance Communications Ltd. and him on a complaint by the State Bank of India, officials said. He was questioned on alleged fund diversion, misappropriation and other irregularities in the loan funds issued to the company by the bank, they said. Mr. Ambani has been called again on Friday for questioning.

SC quashes criminal case against YouTuber Elvish Yadav

The Supreme Court on Thursday quashed criminal proceedings launched by Uttar Pradesh against YouTuber Elvish Yadav in a narcotics and wildlife protection law case involving snake venom as unsustainable in law. A Bench of Justices M.M. Sundresh and N. Kotiswar Singh found that the alleged “psychotropic substance” recovered from a co-accused in the case was not listed in the Schedule of the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act.

Assam polls: Pradyut factor dominates in Congress's list

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

The Pradyut Bordoloi factor dominated the third list of 22 Congress candidates released for the April 9 Assembly polls on Thursday. The Congress retained MLA Asif Mohammad Nazar from the Laharighat constituency and dropped Sibamoni Bora, who defeated BJP heavyweight Angoorlata Deka to win the Batadrava seat in 2021. The two are linked to the resignation of Nagaon MP Pradyut Bordoloi from the Congress. Ms. Bora was travelling with Mr. Bordoloi when their vehicle was attacked in April 2025. Mr. Bordoloi quit the Congress over the party's alleged indifference to his plea not to re-nominate Mr. Nazar, as one of his attackers was reportedly the MLA's close associate. The Congress list names Durlav Chamua as the candidate for the Nagaon-Batadrava constituency, indicating that Ms. Bora is no longer in the party's plans.

24 States, U.T.s set aside funds for new rural jobs scheme

They use past expenditure under the MGNREGA as the baseline as the Centre is yet to notify the formula for determining the State-wise normative allocations under the VB-GRAM (G) Act

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

With the Centre yet to notify the formula for determining State-wise normative allocations under the Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025, at least 24 States and Union Territories have nevertheless earmarked funds for the new rural employment programme. Under the Act, States must bear 40% of the scheme's expenditure, except in the northeastern and hilly States and UTs such as Jammu & Kashmir, which receive a relaxation. Union Rural Development Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan informed the Rajya Sabha on Tuesday that 27 States and UTs are making provisions for the new scheme, though he read out allocations for only 24 of them, amounting to a little over ₹31,000 crore. The Union Budget for 2026-27 has set aside



Under the Act, States must bear 40% of the scheme's expenditure, except in the northeastern and hilly States. AFP

The Union Budget for 2026-27 has set aside ₹95,652 crore as the Centre's share

₹95,652 crore as the Centre's share. Responding to criticism that States may struggle to shoulder their share of the financial burden, Mr.

Chouhan highlighted that even Congress ruled Himachal Pradesh, despite its opposition to the Act, had allocated ₹143 crore. Karnataka, he noted, was the only major outlier. “Many members asked where States will find the money. I am only addressing their anxiety,” he said. A key pending element is the Centre's formula for

Lack of ‘sustainable water sources’ will thwart Jal Jeevan Mission: panel

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

A parliamentary committee has said that the objectives of the Jal Shakti Ministry's flagship ₹8.69-lakh-crore Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM) – that aims to provide consistent and potable water supply to all rural households – will remain “unfulfilled” if sustainable sources of water supply are not found. This comes after an official in the Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation – an arm of the Ministry – told the committee that despite taps under the scheme having been installed at many places, there was an “...issue of water availability due to shortage of sources” and that in some places “...water sources were being exhausted within a year or two”. This prompted the committee to observe that “...the objective of providing water for the next 25-30 years under JJM will remain unfulfilled due to lack of source sustainabili-



The programme, originally envisioned to achieve 100% coverage by 2024, has been stuck at around 81% since 2025. K. MURALI KUMAR

ty”. Sources include rivers, lakes, ponds or any natural pool. The committee recommended that the Ministry implement “source to tap” schemes, under which the entire chain of water supply such as the source of water, tank, supply, were accounted for. There are 6.83 lakh sanctioned schemes under the JJM. The committee “note(d) with concern” that there was no information from the States on how many of these schemes were “source to tap”. The panel said it was “...of the view

means, or by any other means, to convert or abet the conversion of any person or persons from one faith or religion to another,” according to the Bill. The Bill broadens the definition of allurements to include monetary benefits, gifts, employment, free education or medical facilities, promises of better lifestyle, or marriage. “Coercion”, according to the Bill, includes psychological pressure, physical force, or threats, including social boycott. It also proposes publishing “details of the proposed religious conversion on its official website maintained by the competent authority under this Act”, and the setting up of special courts to hear all such cases registered under the proposed law. Mass conversions, which the law defines as the conversion of two or more persons, may attract imprisonment of not less than 10 years, extendable to life imprisonment, and fines of ₹25 lakh or more, while repeat offenders may face life imprisonment.

X accounts posting content critical of govt. ‘withheld’

Aroon Deep
NEW DELHI

A number of people who post content critical of the government on their X accounts were greeted late on Wednesday evening with an email from the social media platform, telling them that their accounts were now withheld in India. The reason: a take-down order issued by the Union government under Section 69A of the Information Technology Act, 2000. The accounts, many of which are run under pseudonyms, posted memes and other content criticising the government in the weeks and months leading up to their handles being censored. The accounts and posts remain visible to X users outside India. The Internet Freedom Foundation (IFF), a Delhi-based digital rights advocacy, called the censorship “alarming,” and said that “independent reporting documented takedowns affecting speech that appears political, satirical, or



The accounts and posts remain visible to X users outside India.

critical, rather than clearly unlawful”. Congress spokesperson Supriya Shrinate said at a press briefing in Delhi that this censorship was an “extremely dangerous trend”. Ms. Shrinate accused the government of deciding “what is acceptable, what is not acceptable on social media”, adding that “anything critical of the Prime Minister will have to go”. The accounts targeted include handles that collectively have lakhs of followers, but are mostly run anonymously. The Caravan magazine said that one of its posts, excerpting a story it published, was also taken down under Section 69A, which allows the government to take down on-

line content by sending a notice to the platforms that host it. The Electronics and Information Technology Ministry did not respond to questions on the take-downs. Over the past few weeks, several individual posts mocking, criticising and satirising the Union government and Prime Minister Narendra Modi have also been “withheld” by X and Meta's Instagram in India, though the government has not directly contacted those who posted this content. None of the deleted posts from this period appear to have been reinstated, even as the IFF said it was helping some users challenge the censorship with the IT Ministry. The IFF, in a statement, called on the “Union government to halt any move to decentralise Section 69A blocking powers further, publish blocking orders only as per the letter and spirit of the Shreya Singhal judgement, and ensure timely notice to affected users with clear grounds and avenues for remedy”.

SUDOKU

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FAITH

Observe silence: Murugan

Verse 12 of Arunagirinatha's Kandar Anubhuti is an upadesa verse, said So.So. Meenakshisundaram in a discourse. Here Muruga's advice to Arunagirinatha is “chumma iru sol ara.” Murugan tells Arunagirinatha to control his thoughts and to be silent. When you are God-realised, you no longer let your thoughts wander. Your mind is no longer agitated over anything. When you have experienced God, your thoughts are refined. But how does one know one has reached this state? A disciple asked Ramakrishna Paramahansa this question. Ramakrishna took the disciple to a place where a woman was making vadas. Ramakrishna asked her how she knew when the vadas were done. She said as long as they were not done, there would be a bubbling sound in the oil. When there was no sound, it meant they were perfectly fried. Ramakrishna told his disciple, “When the mind is under control, there will be no turmoil in the mind. A person who has controlled his senses and mind, will be silent, like the vadas that are done.” When we are waiting for food to be served, we talk with each other. But when food is served, we fall silent, because we are busy eating. Likewise, we talk about mundane things, when we are not focused on God. The moment we turn our thoughts towards Him, we do not feel the need to talk a lot. Siddhars have a lot of power because of their silence and tapas. Kattikulam Suttukkol Mayandi Swami was a siddhar. Mariappa Swamikal, a composer of songs, asked Mayandi Swami to guess what song he (Mariappa Swami) was thinking of singing. Mayandi Swami guessed rightly that Mariappa Swami was thinking of singing the upadesa verse of Kandar Anubhuti.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14746

(set by Vidwan)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY

14 Mother! Clear the decks! (5)

15 Bit unusual! Guys coming before time! (7)

18 Cosy retreats in heavily armed chopper (7)

21 Sharp strong beer? Right!(5)

23 Father! Clean Spooner's line carrying vital liquid! (5,4)

25 Get discouraged as pride crumbles (7)

26 Test pile, lacks one for instance (7)

29 Entertaining team and broken records for those following basics too literally! (15)

Down

1 Impress and get without force (4)

2 Bachelor's field is endless (4)

3 Bare cola cocktail for a tuna (8)

4 Some sweet cherries for one making good impressions! (6)

5 Moody sibling, ignoring cold, writing software (8)

6 Draw feminine force in real shapes (6)

7 Shifted her chair for high priest (8)

8 Like having thick raised joint at centre of a vessel (8)

11 Form of ordinary emptiness (5)

15 Fitfully switch positions (2,3,3)

16 Dead urgent! Prince going out for a dip! (8)

17 Stopped advancement of abnormal growth in the delta (8)

19 Up early in the day all year, as usual (8)

20 First politician to regularly deal and push (5)

22 The AA regularly talk about something that creates immersive drinking experience (3,3)

24 Compact essay about Hoover (6)

27 Present state (4)

28 Some cite as example of simplicity (4)

IN BRIEF

India, a leading importer of fertilisers, is in talks to increase purchases from Russia, Belarus and Morocco as Middle East tensions and China's export curbs risk tightening supplies ahead of the summer planting season, government and industry sources said. India, where farming is a mainstay, imports fertilisers such as urea, diammonium phosphate (DAP) and muriate of potash, as well as liquefied natural gas, a key feed stock for urea production. The Middle East accounts for roughly half of India's DAP and urea imports. REUTERS

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) is working on providing more avenues for the usage of Indian rupee (INR) accumulated by the Russian trade counterparts, a senior official said on Thursday. "We are working on providing various avenues for using the INR, which is accumulated here by the Russian counterparts, to use it either for settling their imports or making capital investments in India, so on and so forth," N Senthil Kumar, chief general manager in RBI's Foreign Exchange Department, said at the Russia-India forum in Mumbai. PTI

NTPC on Thursday said its step-down arm NTPC Renewable Energy has begun commercial supply of 165 MW electricity from 1200 MW Khavda-II solar project in Gujarat. With this, the total installed capacity of NTPC group stands at 88,709 MW and commercial capacity at 87,629 MW, a regulatory filing said. In a separate filing, NTPC Green Energy (NGEL) stated that the current commercial capacity of NTPC Green Energy Ltd Group stands at 9562.68 MW. REUTERS

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI



REPRESENTATIONAL PHOTO

The government on Thursday launched the ₹497 crore Resilience & Logistics Intervention for Export Facilitation (RELIEF) scheme to provide credit insurance cover for exporters whose goods are stranded due to the West Asia crisis, or who are planning to export to the Gulf over the next few months.

The insurance premia under this scheme would be at pre-conflict rates and the focus would be MSME beneficiaries.

While announcing the scheme, the officials of the Ministry of Commerce and Industry acknowledged the hardship being faced by Indian exporters due to the constraints created by

the constraints created by the war in West Asia, and said that the RELIEF scheme was aimed at alleviating this and providing them with surety about their exports.

"Our exporters who have been exporting to the Middle East are facing certain challenges," Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said at a press briefing.

In a separate inter-ministerial briefing, Special Secretary at the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways Rajesh Kumar Sinha said that there are two container ships currently in the Eastern part of the Strait of Hormuz, headed from India to Oman and the UAE. In order to help exporters affected by stuck

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Any attack on Qatar's energy facilities or anything that affects energy supplies from West Asia would impact India, but the country has diversified its sources to deal with the situation, Sujata Sharma, Joint-Secretary at the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) told reporters on Thursday.

Ms. Sharma sought to address concerns about the impact on India's natural gas supplies going forward as Iran launched attacks on Qatar's Ras Laffan Industrial City.

“Forty-seven per cent of our import of LNG is from Qatar, [therefore], any impact there or anything which affects supplies in the Middle East would impact us,” she stated, adding, “We are dealing with it in the sense we are trying to pick up cargoes from other sources.”

Elaborating on the diversification of sources for LNG, she said, "Qatar is definitely a big supplier, however, there are other suppliers, such as Australia and the United States."

Ras Laffan Industrial City was subject to missile attacks from Tehran on Wednesday, causing “extensive damage” at Qatar’s largest LNG facility.

India's natural gas consumption is 195 million metric standard cubic meters per day (MMSCMD), of which half is domestically produced. The remaining 60 mmscmd is routed via the Strait of Hormuz.

Stock plummets to 52-week low as Atanu Chakraborty makes 'sudden exit'; RBI assures investors of sound financial health, corporate governance; Keki Mistry made interim, part-time chairman



Calling it quits: Mr. Chakraborty took over the position in 2021 prior to the merger of HFDC Ltd. with HDFC Bank. FILE PHOTO

press meet on Thursday, Mr. Mistry said, “We really do not understand what led to this kind of reaction [resignation]. I assure all shareholders that there is no material matter at this point of time [that led to the resignation]. Members of the Board asked Mr. Chakraborty about the reason behind his resignation, but he said he had no particular concern.”

“No specific issue was brought to our attention and no specific operational and other issues had been highlighted,” Mr. Mistry said adding ‘the board remains committed to safeguard the institutional values and investors’ confidence.’ He said the bank’s board operated under strong governance standards, robust internal checks and is led by an “experienced management team”

At the age of 71, he said he would not have taken up the responsibility had the bank's governance standards not been in line with his values.

To a query on the reputational loss the bank might have suffered after

the 'abrupt' resignation, Mr. Mistry said, "We will be able to arrest it. The management team and the board are united. Whatever fears are there in the minds of investors will be addressed. Also the RBI has expressed satisfaction with the bank." To another question on any friction between the management, Mr. Mistry said, "It's more of a personal relationship issue. Let's not get into that."

The Hindu attempted to reach Mr. Chakraborty, who took over the position in 2021 prior to the merger of HFDC Ltd. with HDFC Bank, for his comment and to verify the board's version, but his response remained awaited till the time of going to press.

Mr. Chakraborty had reportedly told a TV channel that he stepped down due to ideological differences and not for any organisational malpractices. High drama followed Mr. Chakraborty's resignation as the whole board tried to find an answer to the resignation to which he remained mum. This 'baffled' some of the board members.

It is learnt that he was

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Aiming to keep track of domestic fuel and energy stocks, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) in a notification late on Thursday night designated the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC) as the nodal agency to “collect, compile and analyse” the necessary information.

The gazette notification directs producers and refiners, among others, to furnish to the PPAC information relating to “production, imports, exports, stocks, storage, allocation, transportation, consumption, supply and utilisation of petroleum products or natural gas, aggregated or disaggregated by geography, time or consumers as they may be specified.”

Addressing reporters during the inter-ministerial briefing on Thursday, Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary at the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG), said the move was to provide 'legal strength' to the already-existing mandate of the PPAC. "Now everybody has to give [the necessary] information, and with legal force, it would be better implementable," she said.

The official informed that more than 5,600 consumers had transitioned to piped natural gas (PNG) in the last three days.

Ms. Sharma also said about 1.25 lakh new connections had been provided in the last two weeks.



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Registrar

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 Ph. No. 0145-2640265, email. aceajmer@gmail.com aceajpm.phed@rajasthan.gov.in

S.No. F\ACR\Proj\A\AR-JJM\2025-26/8014 Date: 16/03/2026

CORRIDGMENT NO. 1

In continuation to this office NIT No.03/2025-26 issued vide letter no. 2436-2491 dated 11.02.2026. The following amendments are hereby notified:-

S.N.	Description	As per original NIT	As per this corrigendum
1	Date & time for downloading of tender document	13.02.2026 at 10:00 AM to 16.03.2026 up to 06:00 PM	13.02.2026 at 10:00 AM to 25.03.2026 up to 6:00 PM
2	Date & time for online submission of tender	From 24.02.2026 at 10:00 AM to up to 16.03.2026 at 6:00 PM	Up to 25.03.2026 at 06:00 PM
3	Date & time of physical submission of tender fee, RfSL charges and EMD	17.03.2026 at 01:00 PM	Up to 27.03.2026 at 01:00 PM
4	Date & time of opening of technical bid	17.03.2026 at 03:00 PM	Up to 27.03.2026 at 03:00 PM

All other terms and conditions shall remain same as mentioned in tender document.

(Gopesh Garg)
 Additional Chief Engineer,
 (Project) PHED, Ajmer

DIPR/C/5670/2026

 **Indian Overseas Bank**
Information Technology Department
Central Office: 763, ANNA SALAI, CHENNAI-600002

Indian Overseas bank (IOB) invites bids for the following:

**GOVERNMENT E-MARKET PORTAL -
Supply, Implementation, Maintenance of
Cheque Truncation System (CTS) under
Capex model.**

BID NO: GEM/2026/B/7367951
DATED 17.03.2026

The Above GEM Tender document is also available and can be downloaded from the following websites **www.iob.bank.in** & **www.gem.gov.in** For Tender details and future amendments, if any, keep referring to the following website **www.gem.gov.in**



GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA, "e"-PROCUREMENT NOTICE
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER, KHORDHA (R&B) CIRCLE, KHORDHA
WORKS DEPARTMENT

Tender Call Notice E-mail: rbcirclekhorda@gmail.com

Bid Identification No. CCE-Khordha (R&B) Circle - 15/2025-26 **Memo No -611 Dt.12.03/2026**

The Chief Construction Engineer, Khordha (R&B) Circle, Khordha on behalf of Governor of Odisha inviting percentage rate bid in double cover system in ONLINE MODE from eligible contractors for Road works as detailed in the table below:

1. Nature of Work	: Road Works
2. No of Work	: 1 No
3. Tender Cost	: Rs.10000.00 (On-Line)
4. Class of Contractor	: A & Special Class
5. Available of Bid document in the Website	: From 10.00 AM of Dt.23.03.2026 up to 05.00 PM of Dt.07.04.2026
6. Date of opening of Bid	: Dt.08.04.2026 at 11.30 AM
7. The Bidders have to participate in ONLINE bidding only. Further details can be seen from the Website: https://tenderodisha.gov.in . Any Addendum / Corrigendum / Cancellation of tender can also be seen in the said website.	

Chief Construction Engineer, Khordha (R&B) Circle, Khordha

34001/204/2526 O.P.R-34001/341271/25-26/0006

MARKET WATCH		
	THURSDAY	% CHANGE
Sensex	74,207	-3.26
Gold	1,53,300	-4.36
Brent oil	110.70	-

NIFTY 50		
	PRICE	CHANGE
Adani Energy	1936.80	-70.40
Adani Ports	1356.00	-45.90
Apollo Hosp	7252.00	-219.00
Asian Paints	2186.00	-75.10
Axis Bank	1207.00	-46.20
Bajaj Auto	8868.50	-402.50
Bajaj Finserv	8714.90	-76.90
Bajaj Finance	1324.20	-47.90
Bharat Elec	430.80	-11.80
Bharti Airtel	1827.00	-28.40
Cipla	1239.20	-29.30
Coal India	454.20	-1.00
Dr Reddys Lab	1274.50	-20.30
Eicher Motors	6793.00	-234.50
ECML Tech	228.74	-13.80
Grossup Ind	2607.90	-115.20
HCL Tech	1311.80	-45.40
HDFC Bank	798.20	-44.85
HDFC Life	633.50	-9.85
Hindalco	897.05	-36.00
Hind Unilever	2077.30	-58.00
ICI Bank	1250.10	-39.20
IntGlobalAvi	4154.30	-206.30
Infosys	1220.80	-46.30
ITC	298.00	-6.05
Jo Financial Servic	-	-
Jio	239.45	-8.75
JSW Steel	1130.90	-57.40
Kotak Bank	368.15	-7.25
KPIA	348.90	-373.40
M&M	3045.40	169.20
Maruti Suzuki	12599.00	449.00
Max Healthcare	953.10	-26.70
NestleIndia	1186.30	-18.50
ONGC	269.10	-4.45
NTPC	67.40	4.10
PowerGrid Corp	296.70	-2.70
Reliance Ind	1384.80	-23.30
SBI Life	1903.10	-59.40
State Bank	1048.90	-20.90
Shriram Finance	-	-
Ltd.	949.80	-71.80
Sun Pharma	1744.40	-33.90
TataConsumerPro	-	-
ducts	1044.60	-30.50
Tata Steel	190.51	-4.40
TCS	2356.00	-84.80
Tech Mahindra	1340.60	-44.60
Titan	4037.90	-107.60
Tata Motors PV	309.30	-15.45
Trent Ltd.	3481.90	-159.00
UltraTech Cement	10814.00	-433.00
Wipro	188.41	-5.89

Coal India arm BCCL on Thursday said it has achieved a record single day coal booking of about 2.37 lakh tonnes under its special discount scheme aimed at liquidating stockpiles. Under the scheme, discounts ranging from ₹100-600 per tonne were offered across various slabs, which received an encouraging response. PTI

TEHRAN
Iran says it hit U.S. F-35; jet lands safely, pilot stable, says Centcom



Iran's state TV, quoting a Revolutionary Guard statement, said on Thursday that the country's air defence system hit an F-35 jet. U.S. Central Command said an F-35 fighter jet was forced to make an emergency landing after flying a combat mission over Iran, adding that the aircraft landed safely and pilot was in "stable" condition. AP

PARIS
Iran hangs three men in the first executions over January protests



Iran executed three men on Thursday who were accused of killing police officers during protests in January. They were the first hangings Iran has carried out related to the nationwide demonstration. Rights groups said the trio were executed without a fair trial and had given confessions under torture. AFP

LONDON
'Russian tanker shipping more than seven lakh barrels of oil to Cuba'



A sanctioned Russian tanker is shipping more than seven lakh barrels of oil to Cuba as the communist island suffers blackouts under a U.S. economic blockade, marine trackers indicated on Wednesday. The *Anatoly Kolodkin* loaded 7,30,000 barrels of crude from Russia and was bound for Cuba, Kpler said. AFP

WASHINGTON
U.S. approves over \$16 bn in arms sales to Gulf states hit by Iran war



The United States on Thursday announced the approval of \$16.46 billion in military sales to the United Arab Emirates and Kuwait, two Gulf states that have been hit hard by fallout from the Iran war. The UAE also received approval to buy systems designed to defeat small, unmanned aircraft for \$2.1 billion. AFP

Hezbollah says it is battling Israel's advance in Lebanon

Hezbollah claims to have destroyed up to five Merkava tanks with guided missiles; Israeli troops are 'systematically destroying' villages with 'intense air strikes and overnight artillery shelling'

Agence France-Presse
BEIRUT

Hezbollah said on Thursday its fighters were battling Israeli forces in south Lebanon, as a military source on the ground said Israeli troops were slowly advancing while "systematically destroying" border towns. Lebanon was drawn into the West Asia war on March 2 when Iran-backed Hezbollah attacked Israel to avenge the killing of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. Israel responded with intense strikes on Lebanon that have killed at least 968 people and displaced over a million more, according to local authorities, and by launching ground operations in the south. In a statement, Hezbollah said its fighters had ambushed Israeli troops entering the border town of Taybeh and destroyed a tank. "The enemy then at-



Rising tension: Israeli tanks seen on the Israeli side of the border with Lebanon in the Upper Galilee in Israel on Thursday. AFP

tempted to continue its advance" from a nearby area, but fighters "again targeted them with guided missiles, scoring direct hits and destroying five Merkava tanks", Hezbollah added. "Enemy soldiers were seen fleeing the area of engagement." The Israeli army announced on Monday that it had launched "limited" ground operations in Lebanon. A military source in

south Lebanon said that the Israeli army was advancing slowly and "systematically destroying" the border villages it enters. Lebanon's state-run *National News Agency* reported a "violent night" in Khiam and Taybeh, saying the towns were "targeted by several air strikes and subjected to heavy artillery shelling that continued until dawn". On Wednesday, Hezbollah said it had repelled an

attempt by "Israeli enemy soldiers to advance" in Khiam. In recent days, the group has reported targeting Israeli forces on the border with Lebanon and inside Lebanese towns such as Khiam. The town overlooks part of southern Lebanon and northern Israel and was the first point into which Israeli forces advanced after the start of the war. It was also the site of intense clashes between Israeli forces and Hezbollah during their last war in 2024. Israel has issued warnings to all residents south of the Zahrani River, more than 40 km from the border, to evacuate, and has said it wants to create a buffer zone in Lebanon to protect residents of north Israel. On Wednesday, the UN peacekeeping force said it was deeply concerned by a "violent escalation" in Lebanon. Recently, the United

'U.S. may 'unsanction' Iran oil already being shipped'

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

U.S. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said on Thursday that Washington might "unsanction" Iranian oil that is already being shipped, as energy prices soar due to the war in the West Asia. Mr. Bessent's comments to *Fox Business* came as oil and gas prices made a renewed surge after Iran hit the world's biggest liquefied natural gas (LNG) facility in Qatar and threatened to destroy the region's energy infrastructure. Mr. Bessent added in the interview that the U.S. government could also release more oil from its strategic reserves. U.S. President Donald Trump's administration has been scrambling to rein in rocketing energy costs after U.S.-Israeli strikes on Iran on February 28. Tehran's retaliation brought commercial shipping through the Strait of Hormuz to a virtual halt, snarling energy supply chains. Recently, the United



Scott Bessent

States also temporarily allowed the sale of sanctioned Russian oil that is at sea. On Wednesday, Mr. Trump temporarily waived a century-old maritime shipping law in an attempt to help ease energy prices. **Soaring debt** The national debt surpassed a record \$39 trillion on Wednesday, a milestone that comes just weeks into the U.S.-Israeli war in Iran. The unprecedented figure highlights competing administration priorities, from passing a massive tax law and boosting defence spending and immigration enforcement to chipping away at the debt itself – the latter of which Mr. Trump promised to do as both a

candidate and as President. The Government Accountability Office outlines some of the impact of rising government debt on Americans – including higher borrowing costs for things like mortgages and cars, lower wages from businesses having less money available to invest, and more expensive goods and services. Advocates for a balanced budget also warn that the long-term trend of borrowing more and paying more in interest will force Americans to face tougher fiscal tradeoffs ahead. Michael Peterson, chair and CEO of the non-profit Peter G. Peterson Foundation, created to raise awareness of America's long-term fiscal challenges, said in a statement that "we must recognise this alarming rate of growth and the significant financial burden we are putting on the next generation." White House economic adviser Kevin Hassett estimated that the war in Iran had cost the U.S. more than \$12 billion so far. (With AP inputs)

Iran missile fire kills three Palestinians in West Bank

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Iranian missile attacks have killed three Palestinian women in the occupied West Bank and a foreign worker in central Israel, medics said on Thursday. Falling shrapnel struck a hair salon in the West Bank town of Beit Awa near Hebron late Wednesday, killing the three women, according to the Palestine Red Crescent Society, marking the first Palestinian deaths from Iranian attacks in the ongoing West Asia war. The victims include 17-year-old Mays Ghazi Masalmeh, according to the official Palestinian news agency, *Wafa*. The Red Crescent said at least eight others were wounded, including one woman in critical condition. A short while later, Israeli medics said Iranian missile fire had killed a man in central Israel, bringing the death toll in Israel from attacks during the ongoing war to 15.

Iraq's Kurdistan is becoming the new frontline in a widening Iran war

NEWS ANALYSIS
Anisha Dutta

On March 10 night, the skies above Erbil – the capital of Iraq's autonomous Kurdistan Region – flashed with the streaks of air defence interceptors. According to Erbil's governor, at least 17 drones targeted the city in a single night, triggering sirens and sending residents scrambling indoors – a stark reminder that one of the West Asia's most stable corners is now being drawn into a widening regional confrontation. Debris crashed into a civilian home near the U.S. consulate and landed close to a major public venue. Northern Iraq's autonomous Kurdish region, which hosts several Iranian Kurdish opposition groups, has seen a slew of such attacks since the war in what officials describe as a rapidly escalating campaign in the region. The strikes hitting the

region now come from multiple directions: Iranian missile attacks targeting Kurdish opposition groups based in northern Iraq, drone strikes by Iran-aligned militias targeting U.S. bases, and retaliatory operations linked to the widening confrontation between Tehran and Washington. **Muted response** Kurdish lawmakers in Baghdad warn that the federal government's muted response risks further destabilising the country. Civilian areas have also been affected: among those wounded in recent strikes were a delivery driver in Erbil, a nurse in a camp near Koya, and a child in the Qalawa neighbourhood of Sulaimaniyah. Since February 28, when the U.S. and Israel intensified their attack on Iran, the Kurdistan Region has endured 307 strikes by the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) and affiliated groups, killing eight

people and injuring 51, according to Community Peacemaker Team-Iraqi Kurdistan. "In addition to the loss of life, the attacks carried out by the IRGC, and its affiliated groups have caused damage to civilian homes, oil fields, telecommunications infrastructure, hotels, public spaces, and government and civil institutions," said Kamanan Osman, a member of the CPT Iraqi Kurdistan team. Among the dead were a security employee at Erbil International Airport, four Kurdish fighters linked to Iranian opposition groups, and a French soldier killed in a drone strike on a joint military base southwest of Erbil. The confrontation between Iran, the U.S. and Israel are increasingly spilling across borders and threatening to pull Iraq back into a conflict it has struggled for years to escape. Northern Iraq has long served as a sanctuary for Iranian Kurdish dissidents. Several organisa-



The shadow of a Kurdish fighter falls on the shrapnel scarred wall of a damaged building, after an Iranian drone attack, in Erbil. AFP

tions, including the Democratic Party of Iranian Kurdistan (PDKI), the Kurdistan Free Life Party (PJAK), Komala Party of Iranian Kurdistan, Komala Party of the Toilers of Kurdistan, PAK and Khabat, maintain armed camps, political offices and refugee camps in the region. On February 22, six of these groups announced the formation of the Alliance of Political Forces of Iranian Kurdistan, an umbrella coalition opposing the Iranian government.

Some of these groups maintain armed wings and have historically conducted operations against Iranian forces inside Iran's Kurdish regions. In recent weeks, speculation surfaced in Washington that such fighters could potentially play a role in a broader pressure campaign against Tehran. U.S. President Donald Trump, at one point, suggested it would be "wonderful" if Iranian Kurdish forces based in Iraq crossed into Iran to attack

Iranian forces, a remark that alarmed Kurdish leaders and risked provoking Tehran. Mr. Trump later appeared to walk back the suggestion, saying the U.S. did not want to complicate the war further. The Iranian Kurdish groups themselves have denied any coordinated role in the conflict so far. The escalation is pulling U.S. forces in Iraq back into confrontation against their old adversary: Iran-backed Shia militias that battled U.S. forces during the years following the 2003 U.S. invasion that toppled Saddam Hussein. Militias allied with Tehran have launched dozens of drone and rocket attacks on American targets, including facilities near Erbil International Airport, a base used by U.S. forces at Harir, and even the U.S. Embassy compound in Baghdad. For years, the U.S. sought to wind down its military involvement in the country, but the latest attack could change things

on the ground. Iran holds deep influence in the country through Shia political parties and armed factions collectively known as the Popular Mobilisation Forces (PMF), while the United States still holds significant leverage through security cooperation, economic ties and remaining troop presence. For decades, Iraq has served as a geopolitical crossroads where regional and international actors compete for influence. **'Lawless groups'** Kurdish authorities have stepped-up criticism of Baghdad's response. Saifeen Dizayee, head of the Kurdistan Regional Government's Department of Foreign Relations, condemned what he described as militia drone strikes targeting civilian and diplomatic sites in the region. "We strongly condemn the militia drone attacks on the Kurdistan Region's infrastructure and civilian sites, including the

recent targeting of the UAE Consulate General in Erbil and the U.S. Embassy in Baghdad," Mr. Dizayee said in a statement on Sunday, urging the federal government and security forces to disarm the "lawless groups". Mr. Barzani also held a telephone conversation with Tom Barrack, the U.S. Ambassador to Türkiye and Special Envoy for Syria, during which both sides condemned the recent attacks on the Kurdistan Region and the U.S. Embassy in Baghdad. So far, the conflict has seen more than 7,000 strikes carried out on Iranian targets by the U.S. and Israel, according to US Central Command (CENTCOM), while Iran has responded by launching over 2,000 drones and 600 missiles. It has also begun to disrupt shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, a vital chokepoint for global oil trade. *Anisha Dutta is a journalist based in New York*

Lawmakers in EU move to implement U.S. trade deal

Agence France-Presse
BRUSSELS

EU lawmakers took on Thursday a key first step towards implementing a trade deal with the United States, put on hold after the Supreme Court struck down many of President Donald Trump's tariffs. The European Parlia-

ment's trade committee voted to cut EU tariffs on some U.S. imports as provided under an August deal that Brussels has vowed to stick by – but attached additional safeguards, lawmakers said. "The tariff reductions will only take effect once the U.S. has resolved the chaos following the Su-

Pact was thrown into question after the court ruled Trump lacks authority to impose levies preme Court's ruling," Green lawmaker Anna Cavazzini said. The future of the EU-

U.S. pact was thrown into question after the court ruled in February that Mr. Trump lacks the authority to impose levies under a 1977 law. Mr. Trump responded with fresh duties but that raised complex questions about the implications for the EU deal, which had set tariffs at 15% for most EU

goods. The European Parliament, which has a say on implementing the EU side of the accord, pressed pause on the process last month seeking clarifications. The European Commission said the EU would abide by the pact and had received reassurances the United States would do likewise.



GOVERNMENT OF INDIA-DEPARTMENT OF SPACE
CONSTRUCTION & MAINTENANCE GROUP, SDSC –SHAR
SRIHARIKOTA-524124

Brief E-TENDER NOTICE

No:SHAR: CMG CIVIL:MAINT:E-PT-18/25-26Dt: 18.03.2026

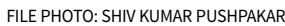
On behalf of President of India, Item Rate tenders are invited through e-tendering for following works;

Name of Work	Tender No	Estimate Cost
Readiness of 150 nos.of vacant/under repair Qtrs in PHC-I & II, SDSC	T/C-25-068	₹ 89.79 Lakhs
Replacement of Joinery in 105 nos occupied Qtrs in PHC-I & II, SDSC	T/C-25-069	₹ 40.56 Lakhs
Supplying & fixing shamiyana and its accessories on hire basis at SDSC for the year 2026-2027	T/C-25-070	₹ 13.71 Lakhs
Arresting roof leakage by PU treatment at Gate-1 Building, SDSC	T/C-25-071	₹ 5.82 Lakhs

Tender documents can be downloaded up to 30.03.2026, 14:30 hrs. For eligibility criteria and other details, interested tenderers may please refer to the detailed bilingual (Hindi-English) Notice Inviting Tenders (NIT) on the website <https://www.isro.gov.in/Tenders.html> and tender free view at <https://www.tenderwizard.com/isro>

Sd/- GROUP HEAD, CMG/ SDSC SHAR

Samson cannot be compared to anyone: Royals skipper Parag



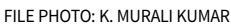
DC unveils jersey in a campaign featuring Axar and Jemimah



Stirling steps down as Ireland T20I captain, will lead in ODIs



Indian men to meet Pakistan on Aug. 19; women take on China



Super Giants should strike a balance between aggression and recklessness

COMPILED BY **G. PRASAD & TARUN SHASTRY**

Jolt for CSK as a hamstring injury lays Ellis low

Bhubaneswar to host World indoor athletics in 2028



CM
YK

R. Kaushik

Liam Livingstone isn't just a journeymen cricketer. He has represented England in exactly 100 internationals across all three formats, is a World Cup winner (T20, Australia, 2022) and briefly captained the One-Day International side in a series against West Indies in November 2024.

The 32-year-old is more than a bits-and-pieces player, as a 20-over average of 28.00 at a strike-rate of 144.70 and 148 wickets at an economy of 8.48 across 340 matches will attest. He is a fantastic ball-striker, a finisher – a role much in demand – and he can bowl off-spin and leg-spin with equal felicity. He is a rare commodity in the modern game, especially in the T20 format where the decided onus is on all-round skills – oh, and did we say he is a gun fielder too?

Livingstone hasn't played for England for more than a year now, since the 50-over Champions Trophy loss to South Africa in Karachi. His last T20I appearance came a month before that, against India in Mumbai in early February 2025. When he was dropped, Livingstone didn't have too many complaints; he didn't have a great T20I tour of India, and his last six ODI innings produced a mere 88 runs. Three of those knocks came at the Champions Trophy, when he made 14, 10 and 9 while batting at No. 7. England lost all three games and were knocked out at the league stage; Livingstone believed at the time that that was the beginning of his problems. Little did he know then how they would spiral beyond control.

In a recent interview with *ESPNcrinfo* that is scathing of the English management, he has called the Champions Trophy 'the worst experience I've had playing cricket'. "I was asking for help and pretty much all I got was that I care too much and I need to chill out a little bit, and everything will take care of itself."

England's first assignment after the Champions Trophy was a home series against West Indies, and Livingstone was promptly dropped. Livingstone has revealed that he got a call from Brendon McCullum, the all-format coach, who told him that they wanted to 'try someone else'. There was a text message from Harry Brook, the white-ball skipper, and nothing at all from Luke Wright, the outgoing selector, Livingstone has maintained. And he has said that when he rang Rob Key, the managing director, the former international batter apparently told him that he was 'busy' at a Test camp in Loughborough.

Damning indictment

Under McCullum and Ben Stokes, the Test skipper, England pride themselves on a culture of inclusiveness, on looking after each other, on being empathetic and understanding. Maybe they are all this, but according to Livingstone, that only applies to those who are in the mix. "If you're in, you're in, and if you're not in, no-one cares about you." That's a

A tale of two think-tanks

The English team management of Brook and McCullum has left Livingstone in limbo while India T20I skipper Suryakumar and coach Gambhir have facilitated the second coming of Kishan and Samson



Livingstone and Samson. GETTY IMAGES & EMMANUEL YOGINI

damning indictment of team culture, if ever there was one.

For all the glitz and glamour associated with sport, cricketers are an extremely sensitive and insecure lot. Even the best are assailed by self-doubt on a regular basis; stalwarts have pointed out that cricket is a game of failure more than it is of success, and that the trick is in trying to prolong the gap between failures, if possible. International cricket's most prolific run-maker, Sachin Tendulkar, for instance, made 50 or more in Test cricket 119 times in 329 innings – that translates to him not scoring a half-century 63.8% of the times he took guard. That's how much the odds are stacked against even the best of the best.

In India, with its vast skill pool and a staggering depth that is a huge tribute to the terrific talent-spotting and nurturing process in play, the scramble for places in the national side is frenetic and often fruitless. For every Ishan Kishan or Varun Chakaravorthy that manages to break in through a combination of sustained brilliance and great fortune – and let's not underestimate the value of luck, ever, though it is never the decisive factor – there are thousands that fail to make the cut. Why, even at the State-level, supply far outstrips demand.

Vital role

When players rise to the top and get into the national side, it is not the end of the journey, even if it feels so, but merely the beginning of one. The goal is not to play alone for India, but to play well, play for the team, contribute to victories and have a long career. But because the process of gatecrashing into the elite mix is so draining and competitive, players need time to find their feet, they need not just opportunities but quality of opportunities. And that's where the role of the leadership group – the captain, the head coach, the selection panel – becomes vitally important.

It's impossible to perform with a clear mind when the sword of Damocles hangs tantalisingly, ominously, over one's head. Crack performances stem from a sense of security, from the knowledge that one will get a longish rope because their entry into the India ranks hasn't been by accident. They emanate from knowing that one has the faith and the confidence and the support and the backing of the team management, whose job it is to provide the perfect environment that will allow each individual to optimise their talent.

There can't be a one-size-fits-all approach, which is where man-management comes into the picture. Different players react differently to the

Out-of-favour Livingstone has called the 2025 ICC Champions Trophy 'the worst experience I've had playing cricket'

same instruction delivered in the same manner. A respected former support staff member once told this writer that if he used the same language with Jasprit Bumrah as, say, with an Umesh Yadav or a Mohammed Shami, he would completely lose the genius from Ahmedabad. As coaches and/or captain, it is important to know what makes one tick, what to say when, when to crack the whip and when to hold back. Coaching, particularly, at the international level is less about high left elbows and impeccable wrist position as about managing people and helping them stay relaxed and in a good headspace. They said of Mike Brearley, the former England captain who didn't have the greatest batting record, that he had a degree in people. No wonder then that he extracted some of the most iconic all-round displays from Ian Botham, tempestuous and volatile but one of the greatest match-winners of all time.

This summary dumping of Livingstone might resonate loosely with Kishan, one suspects. The little fella from Jharkhand was in the process of establishing himself in the Indian side during the unfortunate availability of Rishabh Pant, slowly recovering from his terrible single-car accident of December 2022, when he was dropped from all three formats during the tour of South Africa in 2023-24. A year back, Kishan had smashed a double-century in an ODI in Chattogram; he followed it up with a half-century in his second and last Test appearance, in Port of Spain in July 2023 and opened alongside skipper Rohit Sharma in India's first two matches at the 2023 50-over World Cup, making 0 and 47 respectively while Shubman Gill was recovering from dengue.

By the South Africa tour, the wicketkeeper-batter had lost out to Jitesh Sharma in the T20I set-up, and to K.L. Rahul in the other two versions. Perhaps miffed, he quit the tour midway through in a huff, then foolishly ignored official decrees to represent his state in domestic cricket as he practised at a private academy in preparation for IPL 2024. Punishment was swift and hard-hitting; he lost his central contract and spent a further year and a half on the sidelines which he used judiciously.

Stellar show

Taking well-meaning advice from right quarters on board and readjusting his mindset, he assumed greater responsibility, tempered his happy-go-lucky approach, took his State

to the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy T20 title – it helped that he made a century in the final – and led Jharkhand with imagination and nous. When India mulled a rejig to their batting order just ahead of the World Cup, he received a call from T20I skipper Suryakumar Yadav, asking if he would win the team the title. *Bharosa karoge?* (Will you trust me?), Kishan counter-asked the captain. Suryakumar said yes, Kishan returned in a blaze of glory, finishing as his team's second highest run-getter and lighting up the tournament with his electricity and uninhibited stroke-making.

The man who finished ahead of Kishan in the run-making stakes himself is the beneficiary of tremendous support and backing from Suryakumar and head coach Gautam Gambhir. Sanju Samson played himself out of the XI with a string of low scores against New Zealand in January, but once India felt the need to split their left-handed opening pair of Kishan and Abhishek Sharma midway through the World Cup, the call went to the Kerala man to step in. For more than a decade, Samson had delivered on his promise only sporadically, but even when he lost confidence in himself, the think-tank didn't.

Dispelling self-doubt

They saw in him a gifted but anxious individual weighed down by underachievement, so they set about dispelling the gremlins of self-doubt. Gambhir went to the extent of telling Samson that he wouldn't drop him even after 21 ducks; at nets during the World Cup, whether he was likely to play or not, he received quality batting time. There was a conscious effort to make him feel comfortable and wanted, to give him the assurance that he belonged not just in the15 but also in the XI. When he got his chance, Samson responded in kind. In the three matches that mattered the most, he strung together a sequence of 97 not out, 89 and 89, finally displaying the consistency that his talent demanded but that perhaps his mental fragility repelled.

From fringe player at the start of the competition to Player-of-the-Tournament must be one of the great cricketing fairytale stories in recent times, and while there is no doubt that most of it was Samson, it wasn't just all Samson. And in that lies the victory of the leadership group, of its communication skills and messaging, of keeping the faith and eventually reaping the reward.

Brook and McCullum have their own way of functioning, perhaps vastly different from Suryakumar and Gambhir. The former has left Livingstone in limbo, the latter has facilitated the second coming of Samson. No prizes for guessing in which corner any player would like to be.



THE GIST

- For all the glitz and glamour associated with sport, cricketers are an extremely sensitive and insecure lot
- There can't be a one-size-fits-all approach, which is where man-management comes into the picture
- Samson's stunning turnaround from fringe player at the start of the competition to Player-of-the-Tournament at the T20 WC must be one of the great cricketing fairytale stories in recent times



Kishan. VIJAY SONEJI



A doctor examining a patient during a consultation at a private hospital in New Delhi. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Women and tuberculosis: a story of deprivation, discrimination and debt

Women in India face problems from the very beginning of their TB journey: late diagnoses or misdiagnoses are compounded by stigma, limited mobility, lack of finances and multiple barriers to care; a comprehensive approach to prioritising and tackling their health right through their lifespans could go a long way towards combating TB burden

Bindu Shajan Perappadan

Rekha (named changed) does not like being photographed, has no close friends, and is not on social media. This wasn't the case a few years ago though.

In 2020, Rekha was diagnosed with tuberculosis (TB), having contracted it from her father, who died two years later of the disease. Following the diagnosis, treatment, and cure, the now-28-year-old survivor says, "My diagnosis changed my life forever. The stigma attached to TB runs deep. I don't know if any person other than my own family will accept me." She adds that her close friends abandoned her, and her relatives, fearing shared financial responsibilities vanished. She has made the decision never to get married. Rekha adds that not being married at the time of her diagnosis and treatment was a real blessing. "It would have complicated and hampered my diagnosis, treatment, and recovery," she explains.

Rekha's TB story isn't unique in India. Here, women consistently face life-altering discrimination and stigma following a diagnosis.

Currently India bears the world's highest tuberculosis burden, accounting for over 25% of global cases, with an estimated 2.7 million new infections and over 3 lakh deaths in 2024, as per the World Health Organization's (WHO) Global TB Report 2025. The incidence dropped by 21% from 2015 to 2024, nearly double the global decline rate. The report states that 54% of people who developed TB in 2024 were men, 35% women, and 11% were children and young adolescents.

Social, emotional impacts

Blessina Kumar is a health activist and public health professional with over three decades of experience working with diverse communities across India. "While men carry the larger burden of TB, data alone doesn't tell the entire TB story in India," she says.

Education and financial capacity do not always protect a person from stigma: a TB diagnosis can adversely hit even highly educated, financially independent Indian women, she says. "We worked with a young woman physician from Maharashtra who was married and had enrolled for her specialised medical degree, when she was diagnosed with TB. Overnight she was abandoned by her husband, while the disease took a toll on her physical and mental health. She couldn't continue her studies. It took her a few

Tracking tuberculosis

India's TB incidence (new cases) dropped by 21% from 2015 to 2024, reducing from 237 to 187 per lakh population, says Union Health Ministry. However, significant gender disparities remain

CASE NOTIFICATIONS
Women represent approximately, **36%–37%** of notified TB cases in India, while men account for **58% as of 2023-24**

DEATH OUTCOMES
The death rate among women on TB treatment in India was **3.1% in 2022**

MISSING CASES
Studies indicate that women in India often face higher stigma, with studies highlighting that women may hide symptoms. **Only 58% of women with persistent cough seek timely medical advice, compared to higher rates in men**

SPECIAL CASES
Female genital TB is an emerging issue, with a **1.4%** prevalence reported in studies of specific patient demographics

SOURCES: UNION HEALTH MINISTRY, WHO, INDIA TB REPORT 2024

years to get her life back on track," shares Ms. Kumar. She says very few women, including this doctor who is now a practising paediatrician, are willing to talk about their diagnosis in public. For women, TB brings to the forefront questions about human rights and a woman's ability to make decisions about their own lives. Adequate nutrition, access to monetary resources, fear of social isolation, and hesitation to seek medical care are issues that most Indian women grapple with, Ms. Kumar explains. Alongside the actual disease, Indian women also fight delayed diagnosis, disrupted treatment and almost no mental health support. Ms. Kumar points out that despite the wins in TB elimination, the country has been able to achieve, women and their multi-fold problems persist.

Misdiagnosis, late diagnosis

Speaking about what doctors often encounter when dealing with female patients, Alpa Dalal, head of pulmonary medicine, Jupiter Hospital, Thane, explains that women often hide their TB symptoms, which leads to misdiagnosis and even death.

"The social stigma attached to TB reduces their marriage prospects. Married women face the danger of being abandoned by their husband and in-laws, and not getting any financial help for treatment and care. Women are also often expected to continue

with their daily household work despite the disease, and if they get pregnant during treatment they often stop medicines fearing the side-effects on the foetus," says Dr. Dalal.

Doctors indicate that besides the socio-economic impact, women may experience TB differently from its typical manifestations and this has consequences for how TB is detected and treated. Evidence indicates that pulmonary TB can manifest differently in women, often leading to non-specific presentations such as fever and fatigue. As a result, women may not always exhibit the classic markers doctors associate with TB. Medical professionals who rely on verbal screenings are less likely to suspect women of suffering from TB when they initially reach out, contributing to further diagnostic delays.

Data from WHO's 2025 Global TB Report also shows that a higher proportion of men in India are diagnosed using bacteriological testing methods, whereas women are more likely to be diagnosed clinically, i.e., verbal symptom-based screening or using a chest X-ray without a confirmatory test. The male to female ratio of bacteriologically confirmed adult TB cases detected in India is 3:1.

Issues in diagnosis are further compounded by the reality that women are more likely than men to suffer from certain forms of extrapulmonary (non-lung) TB. While this form of TB is

non-infectious and hence overlooked in global TB prevention programmes that primarily focus on transmission control, it can be debilitating.

One particularly concerning form, genital or reproductive tuberculosis, presents symptoms such as subfertility or menstrual irregularity, which are rarely associated with a typical TB diagnosis. Diagnosis and management of extra pulmonary TB (EPTB) can thus be a problem given the non-specific and atypical symptoms. In 2023, EPTB constituted 24% of the total notified cases and is generally more prevalent in immuno-compromised people.

Healthcare-seeking

Public health professionals say that in India, a woman's lack of autonomy restricts her decision-making power and access to resources, including healthcare. Nutritionally, too, women face a double burden: gender disparities in food security combined with higher nutritional needs during pregnancy, lactation, and menstruation make adolescent girls and women of reproductive age especially vulnerable to malnutrition.

Doctors explain that undernutrition significantly increases women's vulnerability to TB. Undernutrition is recognised as the leading comorbidity among all people with TB in India.

Women's health is often de-prioritised in the family unit making it difficult for them to leave their households and seek professional help. "In India the compounded effects of gender roles, restricted mobility, and an overall lack of awareness places women in a position of vulnerability that is nearly impossible to escape," says Dr. Dalal.

For Meera Yadav, the cost was one lung. The drug-resistant TB survivor recalls the severe coughing, high fever, and chest pain she had 13 years ago. She was finally diagnosed with MDR-TB, but delays in proper testing and limited awareness made her recovery journey difficult.

"I faced severe stigma and discrimination from my family, who isolated and abandoned me instead of offering support. The emotional trauma was as painful as the physical suffering. Due to extensive damage caused by the disease, I lost one lung," she says, adding that her treatment lasted until 2018. She is now a strong TB activist advocating for patient rights and better access to care.

"There is a need to meaningfully engage TB survivors in programme implementation. Survivors can play an important role in providing mental health and psychosocial support,"

she says. The government in 2019 formulated a gender-responsive framework of TB prevention and diagnosis. Its recommendations called for immediate attention and implementation by stakeholders, including the TB programme, frontline workers, and survivor networks.

"The Ministry of Health and Family Welfare launched the TB Mukta Bharat Abhiyaan on December 7, 2024 and among other innovative strategies, is heavily relying on AI-powered chest X-rays to screen asymptomatic TB, also called sub-clinical TB, among high-risk groups, such as the elderly, people living with HIV and diabetes, among others," says a senior Health Ministry official.

Gaps need addressing

Issues with diagnosis apart, gaps in treatment continue to plague the system. As per the 2025 India TB Report, management of EPTB is primarily available at tertiary centres and medical colleges.

Moreover, healthcare providers often do not have up-to-date information on the latest way EPTB is managed. In 2023, the programme developed a training module on extrapulmonary TB. Training healthcare providers to identify non-lung TB at earlier stages will be critical to improve management of this type of TB.

Post-TB complications can also worsen due to late diagnosis. Nearly 50% of survivors develop long-term lung complications, points out Vikas Mittal, director - pulmonologist, CK Birla Hospital, Delhi. Many continue to experience persistent breathlessness and chronic cough even after completing treatment, a condition known as post-tuberculosis lung disease (PTLD).

Survivors are also at increased risk of developing chronic obstructive pulmonary disease (COPD), even if they have never smoked. "Late detection can result in more severe lung damage and higher risk of post-TB complications," he says.

Doctors also explain that women in India have poorer immunity when compared to men, due to lower muscle mass, high incidence of anaemia, poor health-seeking behaviour, unhealthy nutrition and eating habits, and emotional suppression and neglect by family. A comprehensive approach to prioritising and tackling women's health right through their lifespans could go a long way towards combating the TB burden while also ensuring a healthier future for new generations. (bindu.p@thehindu.co.in)

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

U.S. national debt in the wake of the Iran war

39 in \$ trillion. The national debt surpassed a record \$39 trillion, a milestone that comes just weeks into the U.S.-Israeli war in Iran. The unprecedented figure highlights administration priorities, from passing a tax law and boosting defence spending and immigration enforcement to chipping away at the debt itself. AP

Share of sitting RS MPs who declared criminal cases

32 in per cent. Around 32% of sitting Rajya Sabha MPs have declared criminal cases against themselves, while 14% are billionaires, according to a report by the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR). The report is based on an analysis of affidavits of 229 out of 233 Rajya Sabha MPs. PTI

Percentage dip in fire-related calls in Delhi this year

19 in per cent. According to Delhi Fire Services (DFS) data, 2,716 fire calls were received between January 1 and March 15, down from 3,352 in the corresponding period of 2025. Despite this, casualties remain a concern, with 13 deaths and 111 injuries reported, compared to 18 fatalities and 109 injuries during the same period last year. PTI

Number of African migrants who drowned off Comoros

17 At least 17 African migrants who were trying to reach the French Indian Ocean island of Mayotte have drowned off Comoros, the government said. Around 30 people had been found alive after the group arrived near the coastal town of Mitsamiouli, about 40 kilometres from the capital Moroni, a government Minister said. AFP

Rights activists killed in Colombia between 2016-25

1,000 “Between 2016 and 2025, the United Nations High Commission for Human Rights recorded 972 killings of human rights defenders,” an average of nearly 100 deaths a year, the UNHCR said in a statement. AFP
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Oil, power, and politics of disruption

The closure of the Strait of Hormuz disrupts a vital artery of the global economy, triggering price increases and turmoil in energy markets; as supply shocks reshape the geopolitics of energy, countries like India, the U.S., and Russia recalibrate strategies amid shifting oil flows and rising dependence

ECONOMIC NOTES

Jayan Jose Thomas

The blue waters of the Strait of Hormuz, connecting the Persian Gulf to the Arabian Sea, form a vital artery of the global economy. Through this narrow gateway – stretching just 33 km at some points – pass ships carrying nearly a fifth of the oil that is traded worldwide. After the U.S. and Israel launched a military campaign against Iran on February 28, Iran blocked ships passing through the Strait, leading to price increases and turmoil in energy markets.

Global energy flows

Oil and natural gas account for a little over half of the global energy supply (with coal, renewables, and other sources accounting for the rest, according to IEA data for 2024). They fuel vehicles from trucks to aeroplanes, produce electricity and cooking gas, and provide critical raw materials for industries.

West Asian countries around the Persian Gulf, notably Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Iran, are among the largest producers of crude oil and natural gas. At the same time, some of the largest energy consumers are in East and South Asia, particularly China, India, and Japan. Still, these countries have limited domestic oil reserves to power their growing economies (though China is a major natural gas producer) (Chart 1). They depend on crude and natural gas imports from West Asia, much of which passes through the Strait of Hormuz.

America and West Asia

The concentration of energy reserves, especially oil, in a few regions has been the primary trigger for some of the long-standing and intense contests between global powers. Aside from the Persian Gulf countries, only a few nations – the U.S., Russia, Venezuela, and Canada – have large oil and natural gas reserves.

The U.S. has been a principal player in the geopolitics of energy, both a major producer and consumer. Given the gas-guzzling sectors driving its economy, the U.S. has an average energy supply per person that is 10 times that of India and 2.4 times that of China. The hunt for more energy has been one of the primary motives of the U.S. international policies.

Control over oil in West Asia shifted from large American and European firms to state-owned national oil companies since the 1950s. Oil prices increased sharply in the 1970s, with Arab members exerting greater influence within the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries. The U.S. response has been twofold: it increased domestic production by drilling more shale oil, especially since the mid-2000s, making it the world’s largest oil producer, and it tried to mould the geopolitics of oil in its favour through strategic interventions, including the Gulf War (1990-91), the Iraq War (2003-11), recent action in Venezuela (2026), and the ongoing U.S.-Israel war with Iran.

Although current production levels are modest, Venezuela and Iran together account for 39% of the world’s proven oil reserves. The promise of future oil is what makes these countries strategically important, especially in the profit projections of U.S. President Donald Trump. However, the closure of the Strait of Hormuz has, at least in the short term, upset Mr. Trump’s calculations and made Russia an unintended beneficiary of the energy turmoil. Following the

When routes run tight

The closure of the Strait of Hormuz has disrupted a vital artery of the global economy, pushing up oil prices and unsettling energy markets

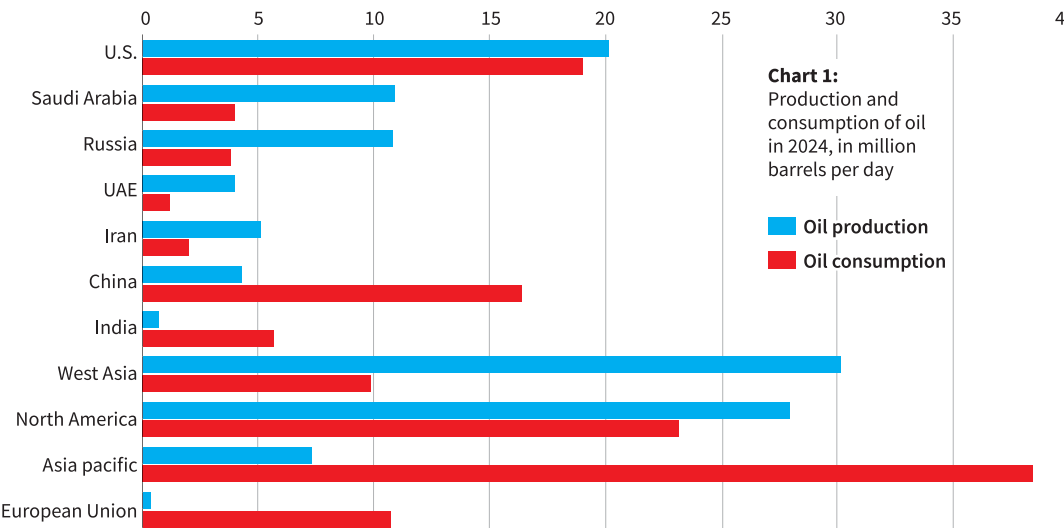
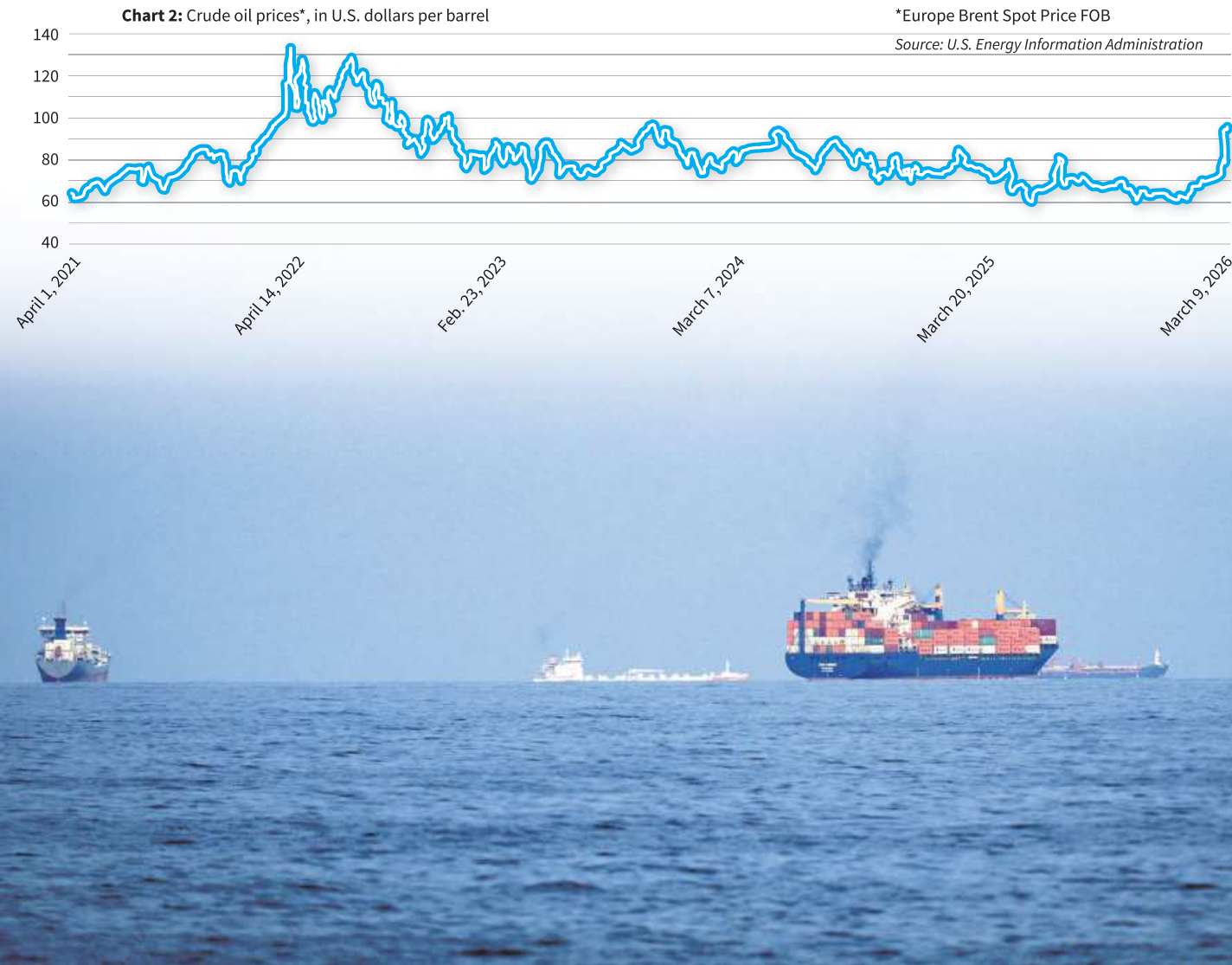


Table 1: Oil trade in 2024, in million barrels per day

	Crude & product imports	Crude exports	Product exports	Net Exports
Saudi Arabia	0.4	6.4	1.2	7.2
Russia	0.0	4.9	2.2	7.0
UAE	0.8	3.7	2.0	4.9
Canada	1.0	4.4	0.7	4.2
Iraq	0.1	3.6	0.5	4.0
U.S.	8.4	4.0	5.9	1.4
India	6.0	0.0	1.9	-4.1
China	13.4	0.0	1.2	-12.2
World	69.4	43.2	26.2	0.0

Source: Global Energy Review 2025, International Energy Agency (IEA)



THE GIST

Oil and natural gas account for a little over half of the global energy supply, with West Asian producers and Asian consumers tightly linked through trade flows.

The U.S. expands domestic production and pursues strategic interventions, while Russia emerges as a key supplier as disruptions hit West Asian output.

India’s purchases of discounted Russian oil boosted its refining and exports. But with global oil prices rising, uncertainty looms.

Russia-Ukraine war in 2022, Russia became a pariah in the West, especially Europe, and trade sanctions have long stymied its oil trade. But suddenly, as oil production capabilities in West Asia take a hit, Russian oil has become crucial for stabilising energy prices. Outside West Asia, Russia is the only country with a large tradable oil surplus (Table 1).

Russian oil and India

The oil markets are deeply interlinked. Even a ripple in a corner of the market can gather itself into a tumultuous wave. India is the world’s second-largest importer of crude oil and the third-largest consumer. Supply disruptions result in higher prices for essential goods and services in India. At the same time, India’s actions in the oil market significantly impact global oil prices.

European countries, with limited domestic oil and natural gas reserves, have traditionally relied on energy

Today, with the Strait of Hormuz closed and oil prices crossing \$110 a barrel, U.S. is desperate to see greater purchases of sanctioned Russian oil

imports, mainly from Russia, to withstand the frosty winters. But with sanctions on Russian products imposed since 2022, Europe has had to seek new energy sources, mainly in West Asia.

In this context, India began purchasing Russian oil at discounted prices. The share of Russian imports in India’s oil purchases increased dramatically – from 2.5% in 2021 to 39.0% in 2023. Notice that crude oil is processed in refineries to convert it into a range of products, including petrol, diesel, LPG, and petrochemicals. While dependent on imported crude, China and India have built large refining capacity and export a portion of their refined oil products.

Some Indian refiners have made large profits by exporting products processed from discounted crude.

Despite their protestations, Western leaders quietly welcomed the stability in oil prices that resulted when demand from India was partly diverted to sanctioned Russian oil since 2022 (Chart 2).

Under strain

Today, with the Strait of Hormuz closed and oil prices crossing \$110 a barrel, the U.S. is desperate to see greater purchases of sanctioned Russian oil, which has long been marooned at sea, to calm the markets.

A week, indeed, can be a long time in international politics. As tensions prolong in West Asia, the global energy order could be reshaped.

(Jayan Jose Thomas is a Professor of Economics at the Indian Institute of Technology, Delhi)

